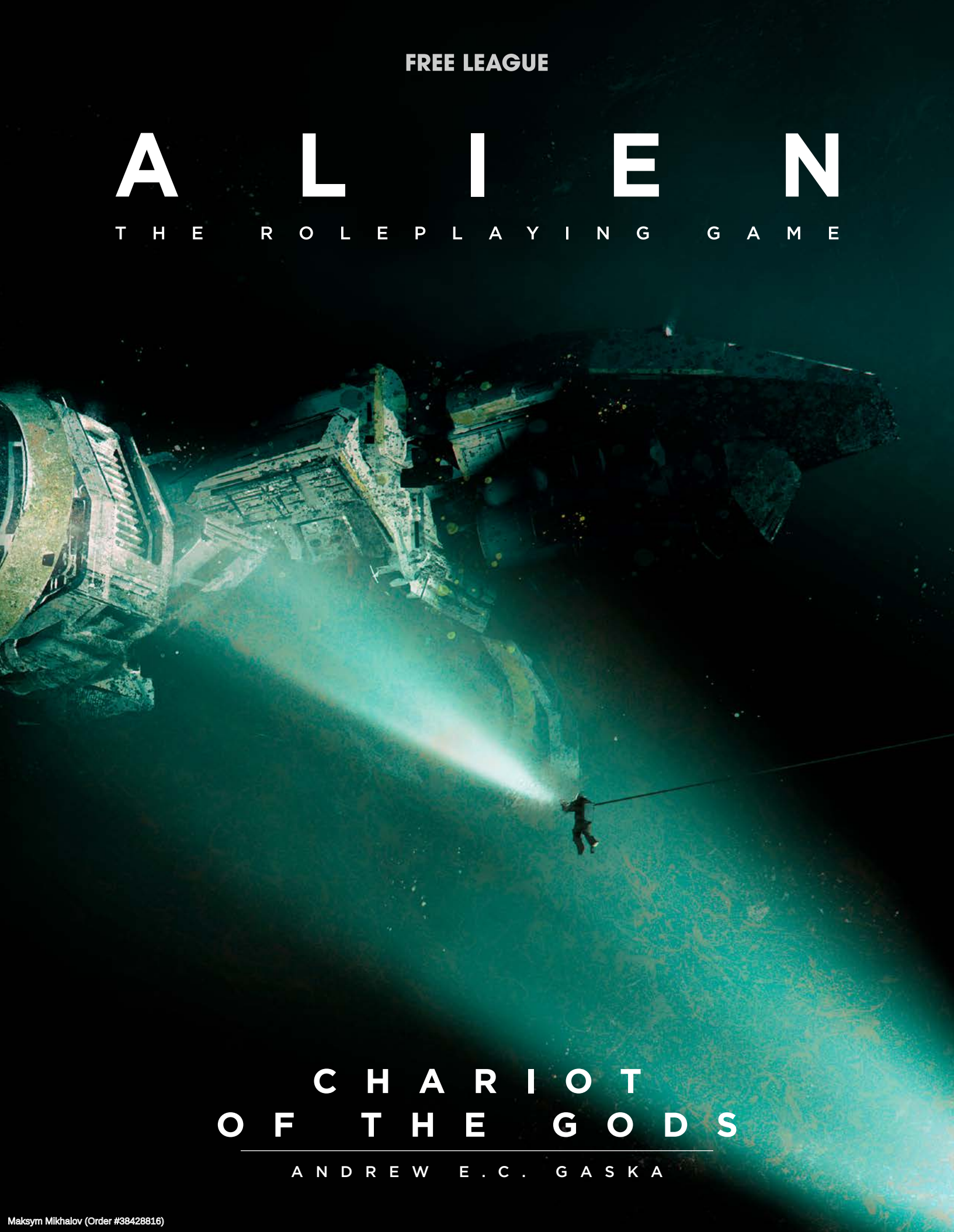
FREE LEAGUE

ALIEN

THE ROLEPLAYING GAME



CHARIOT OF THE GODS

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Maksym Mikhalov (Order #38428816)

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The setup is familiar—a starfreighter intercepts a distress signal in the middle of deep space. The company orders the crew to investigate under penalty of total forfeiture of shares. Finding a derelict ship, they discover an alien lifeform that threatens to kill them—and a member of the crew itself has a corporate directed agenda to protect it.

The particulars of this crime, however, are quite different.

Chariot of the Gods is a complete Cinematic scenario for the ALIEN roleplaying game. It's designed to introduce the game to the players while at the same time take them for a thrilling, terrifying ride into space where no one can hear them scream. The scenario is designed for 3–5 players plus GM, and takes at least 4-5 hours to complete.

"Miss Vickers would like to have a quick word... before the adventure begins."

—DAVID 8

FOR MOTHER'S EYES ONLY

This entire booklet is solely for the GM, to be read before the game begins. Players should NOT read the scenario text beforehand to avoid spoiling the mystery of what is in store for them.

CHARACTERS

This scenario comes with five pre-generated player characters—the crew of the USCSS *Montero* starfreighter. Filled-in character sheets for these PCs can be found in the boxed set. Let the players choose who they want to play. If you have fewer than five players, the leftover crew members are NPCs under your control.

When your players have chosen their starting PCs, read the boxed text entitled "What's the Story Mother?" out loud (see page 4). Then show the players the map of the *Montero* on page 7 and hand each player their Personal Agenda (see next page) for the first Act to kick off the action.

If any of the PCs should die during the course of the scenario, you can use NPCs from the crew of the USCSS *Cronus* or the *Sotillo* as replacements. Let the player choose a Buddy and Rival for their new character if they wish. For replacement PCs, use character sheets downloaded from the Free League website.

GEAR: The PCs start the scenario with no personal gear except their signature items. As the scenario kicks off, the PCs may distribute the gear available on the *Montero* (see page 6) as they—or rather, Captain Miller—sees fit.

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PERSONAL AGENDAS

Each character has a Personal Agenda for each of the three Acts of the scenario. These Agendas are printed on playing cards included in this boxed set. At the start of each Act, give each player their new Agenda for the Act about to start, and tell them not to reveal it to the other players.

SPECIAL ORDER 966: At the start of the scenario, give Wilson's player the card entitled "Special Order 966" in addition to their Agenda.

EVALUATING AGENDAS: At the end of each Act, collect the Agendas from the players and evaluate them individually. If you feel a player has actively advanced their PC's Agenda despite significant personal risk or sacrifice, announce this and award them one Story Point (see page 26 of the rulebook). Don't reveal the actual Agendas to the entire group, they should remain hidden until the end of the scenario.

REPLACEMENT PLAYER CHARACTERS: Only original PCs have pre-written Personal Agendas for the three Acts of the scenario. NPCs used as replacement PCs have only one Agenda that remains the same for the entire scenario. ■

THE SECRET ANDROID

One of the crew members on the *Montero* is in fact a synthetic undercover agent code-named Lucas, working for Bionational—a corporate rival to Weyland-Yutani. After the players have chosen PCs, decide which one of them is Lucas. When you hand out Personal Agendas, replace the chosen PC's Agendas with Lucas's Agendas. At the start of the scenario, give Lucas's player the card entitled "Note to Lucas" in addition to their Act I Agenda. Lucas can be an NPC if you prefer.

To avoid detection, Lucas mimics human behavior to perfection. As long as Lucas is not exposed, use rules for humans for the android—pushing rolls, gaining STRESS LEVEL, making Panic Rolls, etc. Only if Lucas suffers a critical injury is the android automatically revealed—as it bleeds white, not red. From the moment Lucas is exposed, it follows the rules for androids (see page 77 of the rulebook). When exposed, Lucas also shows its true power—the android's STRENGTH and AGILITY increase by +3 each, also affecting Health, including current Health. Lucas's behavioral inhibitors are removed, allowing it to hurt humans.

CALLING PVP. Revealing Lucas as an android has a high risk of triggering direct confrontations with other PCs. If this happens, play out the current scene and then turn Lucas into an NPC, letting the player choose another character (someone from the crew of the *Cronus*) to play.

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WHAT'S THE STORY, MOTHER?

You are space truckers on the starfreighter USCSS Montero, running "the Gauntlet"—the trade route between Anchorpoint Station and the Frontier. Your ship's cargo hold is packed with dozens of tanks of dangerous Tritium gas that is in the process of decaying into extremely profitable Helium-3. Usually cargoes such as these are towed in massive tanker modules that transport much higher concentrations of the gas a safe distance from a freight hauler. The Montero isn't rated as a commercial towing vehicle, however, and this small run is a special order for a Weyland-Yutani corporate account on Sutter's World—a newly established Frontier colony. While the trip so far has been fairly routine, the Montero's sensors developed a glitch before you left Anchorpoint and sporadically pinged contact with a sensor reflection before you activated the displacement drive and went FTL. Your cargo run so far has been without incident. Now, you are just awakening from hypersleep, ready to deliver your goods to the colony of Sutter's World.

THE SITUATION

SCENARIO OVERVIEW

The starfreighter USCSS *Montero* is diverted to check out a distress signal sent by the USCSS *Cronus*, a science exploration ship that has been missing for three quarters of a century. The crew of the *Montero* investigate and find the few remaining *Cronus* crew in stasis and the ship overrun by alien creatures. As they attempt to transfer the survivors to the *Montero*, the starfreighter's reactor is set to overload by one of the crew, who has orders to bring back the xenomorphic materials the *Cronus* is carrying. With their ship destroyed, the *Montero* crew is forced to repair the *Cronus* instead. The crew soon finds themselves caught between corporate agents who put their mission and a paycheck ahead of human lives, the crew of the *Cronus* who are suffering from an infection that is slowly turning them into monsters, feral alien creatures that are out for blood, and a murderous android who wants to stop Weyland-Yutani from getting their hands on anything alien. Just when the *Montero* crew discover that they too might be infected, pirates attempt to seize the ship. It all comes down to one question—does the crew want to stop a dangerous biological weapon from getting into the wrong hands, or do they want to become very, very rich?

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WHAT THE HELL HAPPENED TO THE CRONUS?

Acting on classified data from an encrypted transmission, the *Cronus* was launched in 2110 to attempt to locate samples of Chemical Agent A0-3959X.91–15. Deciphering part of the data transmission led them to the 26 Draconis system and a small planetoid dubbed LV-1113 tucked away in the planetary debris belt shared by the suns of this trinary star system. The chemical was discovered there, but some of it had been previously deployed, causing mutations in the planet's lifeforms.

While the science team modified and experimented with what they called the 26 Draconis strain of the black liquid, members of the crew became infected with Mote pathogen spores, causing them to give birth to Bloodbursters which quickly matured into Neomorphs. Chaos soon broke out. There was a mutiny, the science module on the *Cronus* was ejected and left behind, and the surviving crew escaped the planetoid.

THE 26 DRACONIS STRAIN: Discovering that some among them had been infected by the spores before departing, the remaining scientists used a derivative of the 26 Draconis strain to inoculate the crew against the Neomorph spores. The doctors administering it were unaware that their cure was not completely safe, however—nor that it could cause those inoculated to mutate into Abominations. As some of the inoculated began to transform and others didn't, the crew of the *Cronus* failed to make the correlation.

Nonetheless, as the ship was overrun with Neomorphs and Abominations, they realized they were in over their heads. Barricading themselves on cryodeck and leaving the ship's synthetic—Ava—to maintain the infested ship, they put themselves in stasis and hoped for a miracle.

After being caught in a micro-meteorite storm, navigation control failed on the *Cronus* and her comms array was damaged. Ava was attacked by the Abominations while attempting to repair the engines. Life support failed, plunging the ship into a deep cold. The crew remained safe in their hypersleep chambers, and the creatures aboard went into a state of suspended animation. This all happened within two days of leaving LV-1113. Since then, the *Cronus* has been adrift, barreling along at sublight speeds for decades.

MOTHER'S NOTE: The 26 Draconis Strain inoculation works—95% of the time it does indeed arrest the development of any Neomorph spores deposited by the Motes. Unfortunately, there is also a significant risk of the black liquid derivative going too far and recoding the DNA of the inoculated, slowly transforming them into zombie-like Abominations (see page 43).

"... And all these you shall regard as an abomination."

—LEVITICUS 11:13

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USCSS MONTERO

LOCKMART CM-88G BISON-CLASS FREIGHTER

The *Montero* is of the same series of starfreighter as the *Nostromo*, save that it is a newer model with some minor upgrades. The most important distinction is that the *Montero* has standard Saturn J 3000 engines, instead of the Rolls-Royce N66 Cyclone upgrades that the *Nostromo* had. As such, she is not rated as a commercial tug. She is fitted to haul cargo internally like a standard freighter, and has a cavernous bay with ventral access.

This scenario starts off on the *Montero*, and an overview of the main personnel deck can be seen to the right. The rest of the ship is not mapped out in detail, as it is unlikely that the PCs will spend much time here—see Events.

CARGO: The *Montero's* bay is currently full of 72 high-pressure tanks carrying 200,000 tons of aging yet still highly flammable Tritium. The volatile nature of Tritium means that it can be a bitch to transport, but by the time this shipment reaches port it will have completed radioactive decay into Helium-3—a safe and clean energy source used throughout the colonies. Each tank is half the size of a tanker trailer. When the adventure begins, about half of the gas is still flammable. Extreme caution is advised. To ferry cargo to and from low orbit, the *Montero* is equipped with an ailing WY-37B Flatbed Cargo Lifter called *Daisy*.

PASSAGEWAY UMBILICAL: The *Montero* is equipped with a 10-meter-long passageway umbilical, which can be used to connect to the airlocks of other spacecraft and thus allow passage without the need for a spacewalk. ■

GEAR ON THE MONTERO

The following pieces of gear are available on the *Montero* at the start of the scenario. The PCs—or rather, Captain Miller—must decide on how best to distribute the gear. Details on this gear can be found in Chapter 5.

- **5 x IRC Mk.50 Compression suit (starting Air Supply 5 in each)**
- **1 x M314 Motion Tracker (Power Supply 5)**
- **1 x Cutting Torch (Power Supply 5)**
- **1 x Watatsumi Bolt Gun (4 shots)**
- **1 xM4A3 Service Pistol (1 reload)**
- **1 x SpaceSub ASSO-400 Harpoon Grappling Gun**
- **1 x M240 Incinerator Unit (2 reloads)**
- **1 x P-5000 Power Loader**

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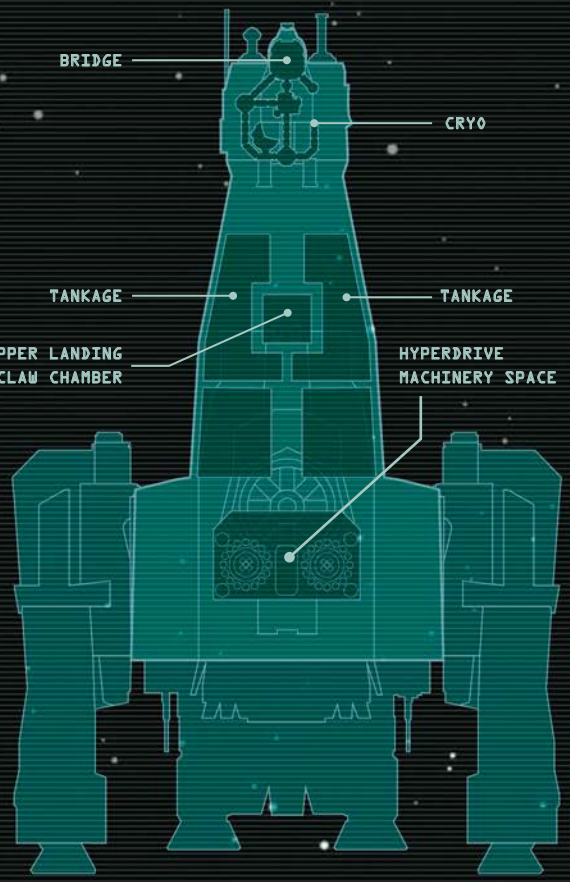
USCSS MONTERO

USCSS MONTERO

COMMERCIAL FREIGHTER



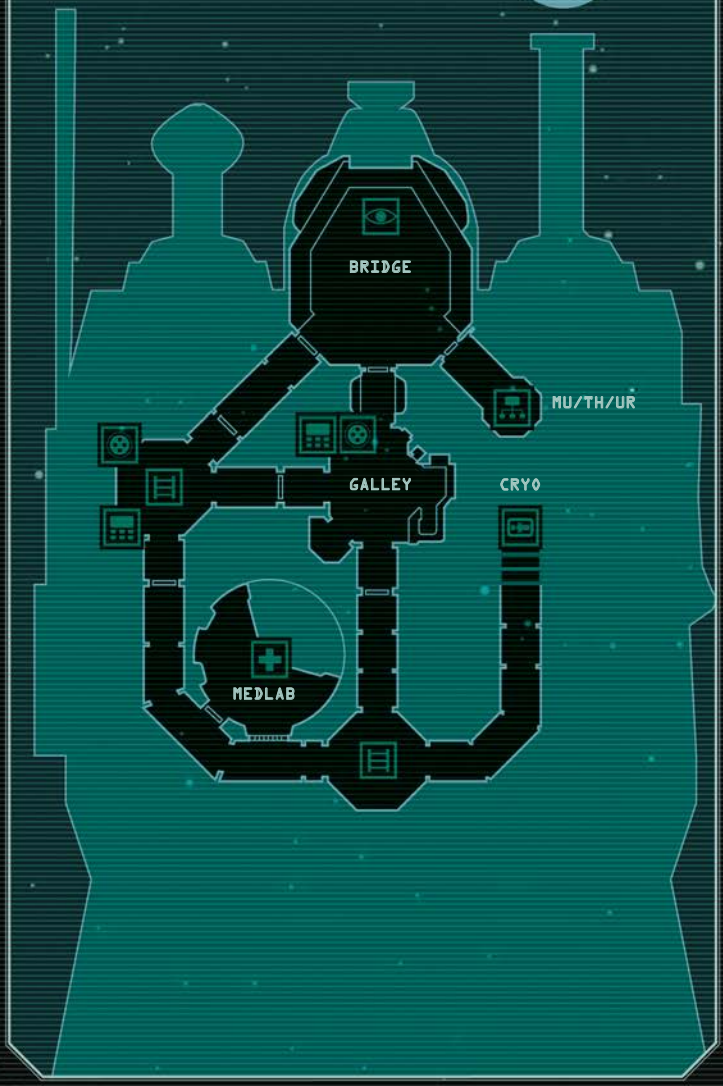
334m



MONTERO - DECK A

DECK

A



WY-37B DAISY



34m

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NON-PLAYER CHARACTERS

During this scenario, the crew from the USCSS *Montero* can encounter NPCs from three different groups, all detailed below.

THE CREW OF THE CRONUS: Originally launched with a crew of thirty, the *Cronus* is down to only five members. They don't even have a pilot left, save for the second officer.

THE CREW OF THE SOTILLO: Shadowing the PCs for the entire adventure, these corporate-sponsored marauders don't reveal themselves until Act III—and just may be the PCs' only way out of this mess.

THE XENOMORPHS: No ALIEN game would be complete without some form of ALIEN, and while the traditional Xenomorph doesn't make an appearance in this adventure, their next of kin are just as deadly. Two types of alien beasts appear in this scenario: Neomorphs and Abominations. Both are described in Appendix I on page 36.

Most of the Xenomorphs are birthed during the course of the scenario, but some are already on the *Cronus* when the PCs arrive:

- Neomorphic Egg Sacs at multiple locations on the ship, ready to infect unwitting PCs.
- A vivisected Stage IV Abomination in the Medlab (see page 22).
- A Stage IV Abomination hibernating in the Reactor Control Room (see page 25).
- A Stage IV Abomination on the outer hull.
- Should you want to add some fuel to the fire, you can add an adult Neomorph also hibernating on the *Cronus*, stalking the PCs as they arrive (see Events).

All xenomorphs on the *Cronus* are considered *active* in stealth mode at the start of the game, *except* the Abominations.

JOHNS, OFFICER



Second Officer on the USCSS Cronus

FULL NAME: Albert Johns

AGE: 47

PERSONALITY: Submissive

Now the de facto Captain of the Cronus, Johns has lost his edge. As someone who is really good at making sure things get done, Johns is also not very good at giving orders. He readily falls in as second-in-command to whomever starts making the hard choices needed to save lives.

STRENGTH 4, AGILITY 3, WITS 3, EMPATHY 4

HEALTH: 4

SKILLS: Heavy Machinery 1, Stamina 2, Ranged Combat 2, Piloting 2, Observation 2, Command 1

TALENT: Pull Rank

GEAR: M4A3 Pistol (1 reload), key card

PERSONAL AGENDA: Find a leader to follow and help them to save human lives.

BUDDY: –

RIVAL: Clayton

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REID, COLONIAL MARINE



Security Officer on the USCSS Cronus

FULL NAME: Valerie Reid

AGE: 34

PERSONALITY: On Edge

An Outer Rim Defense Force veteran of the Civil War on Torin Prime, the 1.50m Sgt. Reid commanded the security team assigned to protect the scientists aboard the *Cronus*. An independent contractor, she was honorably discharged from the ORDF and hired by Weyland-Yutani. Reid lost an arm on Torin Prime, but has a synthetic replacement. She saw a lot of people under ORDF protection die on LV-1113, and suffers from PTSD from both that experience and the Civil War. People tend to underestimate her because of her size.

STRENGTH 5, AGILITY 4, WITS 2, EMPATHY 3

HEALTH: 5

SKILLS: Close Combat 3, Heavy Machinery 1, Ranged Combat 3, Mobility 2, Command 1

TALENT: Overkill

GEAR: Armat 37A2 12 Shotgun (2 reloads)

PERSONAL AGENDA: Terminate all threats to the *Cronus* crew with extreme prejudice, no matter the risks for you.

BUDDY: Johns

RIVAL: Flynn

FLYNN, MEDIC



Ship Medic on the USCSS Cronus

FULL NAME: Liam Flynn

AGE: 27

PERSONALITY: Fearful

The ship's remaining medical doctor, Flynn was one of the junior scientists who helped synthesize the derivative cure from the 26 Draconis Strain. Flynn suspects the cure isn't safe, but he would rather take the chance with it than witness another Bloodburster birth. The doctor is not willing to talk about what happened on LV-1113, nor reveal what other breakthroughs the scientific team achieved before the *Cronus* left them behind. Flynn has not informed anyone that the cure contains the black goo within it.

STRENGTH 2, AGILITY 3, WITS 4, EMPATHY 5

HEALTH: 2

SKILLS: Mobility 1, Observation 2, Comtech 2, Manipulation 2, Medical Aid 3

TALENT: Compassion

GEAR: Personal Medkit, Surgical Kit

PERSONAL AGENDA: Get out of this mess alive, no matter what the cost or what lies you need to tell.

BUDDY: Cooper

RIVAL: Reid

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COOPER, SCIENTIST



Chief Scientist on the USCSS Cronus

FULL NAME: Daniel Cooper

AGE: 53

PERSONALITY: Rational

A scientist assigned to the *Cronus*, Professor Cooper was infected by Neomorphic Motes before he went into hypersleep. He knows that the 26 Draconis Strain cure is derived from the black goo, and feared it was unsafe. He never took his inoculation, instead pocketing his syringe and claiming he had administered the shot to himself. Feeling sick before entering stasis, Cooper quickly deteriorates upon regaining consciousness, complaining of immense migraines before beginning to talk nonsense and going into epileptic shock. See the "Mother of all Migraines" event for his final fate.

STRENGTH 2, AGILITY 3, WITS 5, EMPATHY 4

HEALTH: 2

SKILLS: Mobility 1, Observation 2, Comtech 3, Manipulation 1, Medical Aid 3

TALENT: Analysis

GEAR: Personal data tablet

PERSONAL AGENDA: To make sure the 26 Draconis Strain does not become a threat to human civilization.

BUDDY: Flynn

RIVAL: Clayton

CLAYTON, COMPANY AGENT



Corporate Liaison on the USCSS Cronus

FULL NAME: Lori Clayton

AGE: 42

PERSONALITY: Ruthless

While cool on the surface, Clayton is seething with rage over a life lost in cryosleep. Aware that both Cooper and Flynn have invaluable information and experience regarding the scientific team's experiments on LV-1113, she wants to bring both Flynn and a sample of the 26 Draconis Strain back to Weyland-Yutani for a nice fat paycheck.

NOTE that only Clayton has the codes to the wall safe and the EEV in her quarters on Deck B of the *Cronus*.

STRENGTH 2, AGILITY 3, WITS 4, EMPATHY 5

HEALTH: 2

SKILLS: Ranged Combat 2, Mobility 1, Observation 2, Command 2, Manipulation 3

TALENT: Personal Safety

GEAR: M4A3 Pistol (2 reloads), key card

PERSONAL AGENDA: Bring both Flynn and a sample of the 26 Draconis Strain back to Weyland-Yutani for a nice fat paycheck—no matter who you need to kill to get there.

BUDDY: –

RIVAL: Cooper

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AVA 6, SYNTHETIC



Android on the USCSS Cronus

AGE: Appears to be in her twenties

PERSONALITY: Helpful

Introduced by Weyland-Yutani at the beginning of the century and now long since discontinued, Ava is the female-presenting equivalent of the Walter series android. Considered by the crew to be nothing more than a machine, she was locked outside the cryodeck in an attempt to maintain the ship despite its Neomorph infestation. Damaged soon afterwards, she has wandered the ship in a daze for decades. Ava believes in duty and service, and always puts humankind before herself, even when they do not deserve it.

STRENGTH 5, AGILITY 6, WITS 5, EMPATHY 4

HEALTH: 5

SKILLS: Mobility 1, Stamina 2, Observation 2, Comtech 3, Medical Aid 2

GEAR: None

PERSONAL AGENDA: Help the humans on the *Cronus* survive, without regard to your own safety.

BUDDY: –

RIVAL: –

BOLAJI, OFFICER



Captain of the Sotillo

FULL NAME: Adisa Bolaji

AGE: 30

PERSONALITY: Resolute

Awkward, tall, and gaunt, Bolaji isn't your typical criminal. Under contract from Seegson, the captain is paid to harass Weyland-Yutani ships on the Frontier. This pirating gig is a full time job with benefits and paid vacation for him and his entire crew, not to mention bonuses for any unique hauls they might bring in. While everything is business first, Bolaji also knows that some things are too dangerous to be left in the hands of the wrong people.

STRENGTH 3, AGILITY 5, WITS 3, EMPATHY 3

HEALTH: 3

SKILLS: Heavy Machinery 1, Mobility 2, Piloting 1, Ranged Combat 3, Manipulation 1, Command 2

TALENT: Pull Rank

GEAR: Rexim RXF-M5 EVA Pistol (3 reloads)

PERSONAL AGENDA: Turn this tricky situation into a profit without risking your ship and crew.

BUDDY: Pin

RIVAL: –

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PIN, MERCENARY



Hired muscle on the Sotillo

FULL NAME: Pinion

AGE: 31

PERSONALITY: Steadfast

Pinion grew up with Bolaji in the Solomons. In their teens, they stole moon shuttles together. A year older than Bolaji, Pinion once accidentally crashed a commercial transport while joyriding and wounded six people. Bolaji took the fall and went to juvie for the crime, keeping Pinion from suffering a real prison sentence. She has stayed loyal ever since. At 1.95m, Pin is the muscle of the *Sotillo* crew. Pinion enforces Bolaji's will.

STRENGTH 5, AGILITY 4, WITS 3, EMPATHY 2

HEALTH: 5

SKILLS: Close Combat 3, Heavy Machinery 1, Stamina 1, Ranged Combat 2, Mobility 2, Command 1

TALENT: Overkill

GEAR: Armat M41A Pulse Rifle (2 reloads)

PERSONAL AGENDA: Follow and protect Bolaji, no matter what the cost or risk.

BUDDY: Bolaji

RIVAL: Bein

BEIN, PILOT



Pilot on the Sotillo

FULL NAME: Helen Bein

AGE: 53

PERSONALITY: Cynical

A former combat pilot for the Colonial Marines, Bein was dishonorably discharged for nuking the wrong outpost during the Tientsin Campaign. An alcoholic, Bein is still a better pilot drunk than most colonial pilots are sober. Bein's military knowledge and experience have been invaluable to the *Sotillo*.

ALCOHOLIC: Se page 67 of the rulebook.

STRENGTH 3, AGILITY 5, WITS 3, EMPATHY 3

HEALTH: 3

SKILLS: Heavy Machinery 2, Ranged Combat 2, Piloting 3, Observation 1, Command 2

TALENT: Reckless

GEAR: .357 Magnum Revolver (2 reloads)

PERSONAL AGENDA: Find a drink on this goddamn ship.

BUDDY: Horton

RIVAL: Pin

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HORTON, MECHANIC



Mechanic on the Sotillo

FULL NAME: Micky Horton

AGE: 12

PERSONALITY: Friendly

The twelve-year-old son of a minor Weyland-Yutani exec that shafted Bolaji on a deal, Horton was kidnapped by the captain in an attempt to get the exec to pay up. When Horton's father was killed by another mercenary he hadn't paid, Bolaji decided to keep the kid. The self-taught and scruffy mechanic has been rebuilding sensor suites and assembling thruster arrays since the age of nine. The boy is well-liked and well-treated by the crew of the *Sotillo*.

STRENGTH 2, AGILITY 4, WITS 5, EMPATHY 3

HEALTH: 2

SKILLS: Mobility 2, Observation 2, Survival 2, Comtech 3, Medical Aid 1

TALENT: Beneath Notice

GEAR: M240 Incinerator Unit (1 reload)

PERSONAL AGENDA: Help your crewmates from the *Sotillo* to get out alive.

BUDDY: Bein

RIVAL: –

USCSS CRONUS

WEYLAND SEV M3 HELIADES-CLASS SCIENCE EXPLORATION VEHICLE

The *Cronus* is a science exploration vehicle launched at the beginning of the 22nd century. Modern vessels in this design lineage are of the Magellan class, and a PC might mistake the ship for its newer brethren. Just as the *Montero* is a slightly newer variant of the *Nostromo*, The *Cronus* is a variant of a Heliades-class ship with many similarities to the *Prometheus*. On the *Cronus*, however, the separate Class D module was not a lifeboat, but instead a classified and specially-equipped science lab that could be jettisoned in the case of an emergency. When the PCs encounter her, that module is missing, ejected at some point during the SEV's original mission.

AUXILIARY VEHICLES: The *Cronus* has only two ATVs (see page 141 of the core rulebook) in her vehicle bay, and is missing all of her Class A escape pods. Wherever she was, whatever she was doing, she left in a hurry—and left her vehicle complement behind.

THE DECK PLANS: The *Cronus* has four decks, each accessible through main junction ladderways, two large elevators, and a staircase (that is collapsed). You'll find the deck plans in the center of this booklet for easy removal. Each room or corridor is one *zone* for the purposes of movement (see page 55 of the rulebook). Larger rooms are divided into several zones, separated by thin lines. The dotted lines are ventilation ducts, with larger dots marking zone limits.

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CRONUS - DECK A

USCSS CRONUS

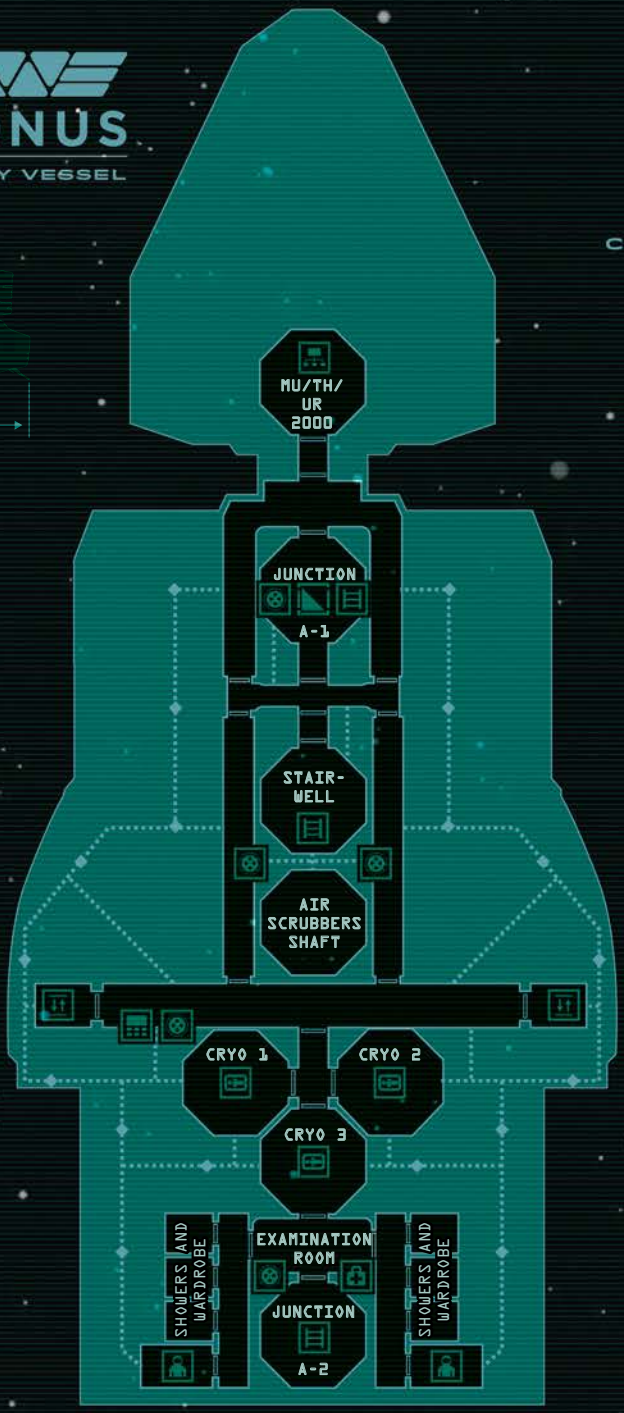
SCIENTIFIC EXPLORATORY VESSEL

DECK A

2X2 METERS

CRYO DECK





TECHNICAL SPECIFICATIONS

LENGTH: 130 metres

WIDTH: 48.75 metres

HEIGHT: 36.5 metres

ENGINE POWER: Four nuclear-powered ion plasma engines

FUEL SOURCE: Ionized plasma drive

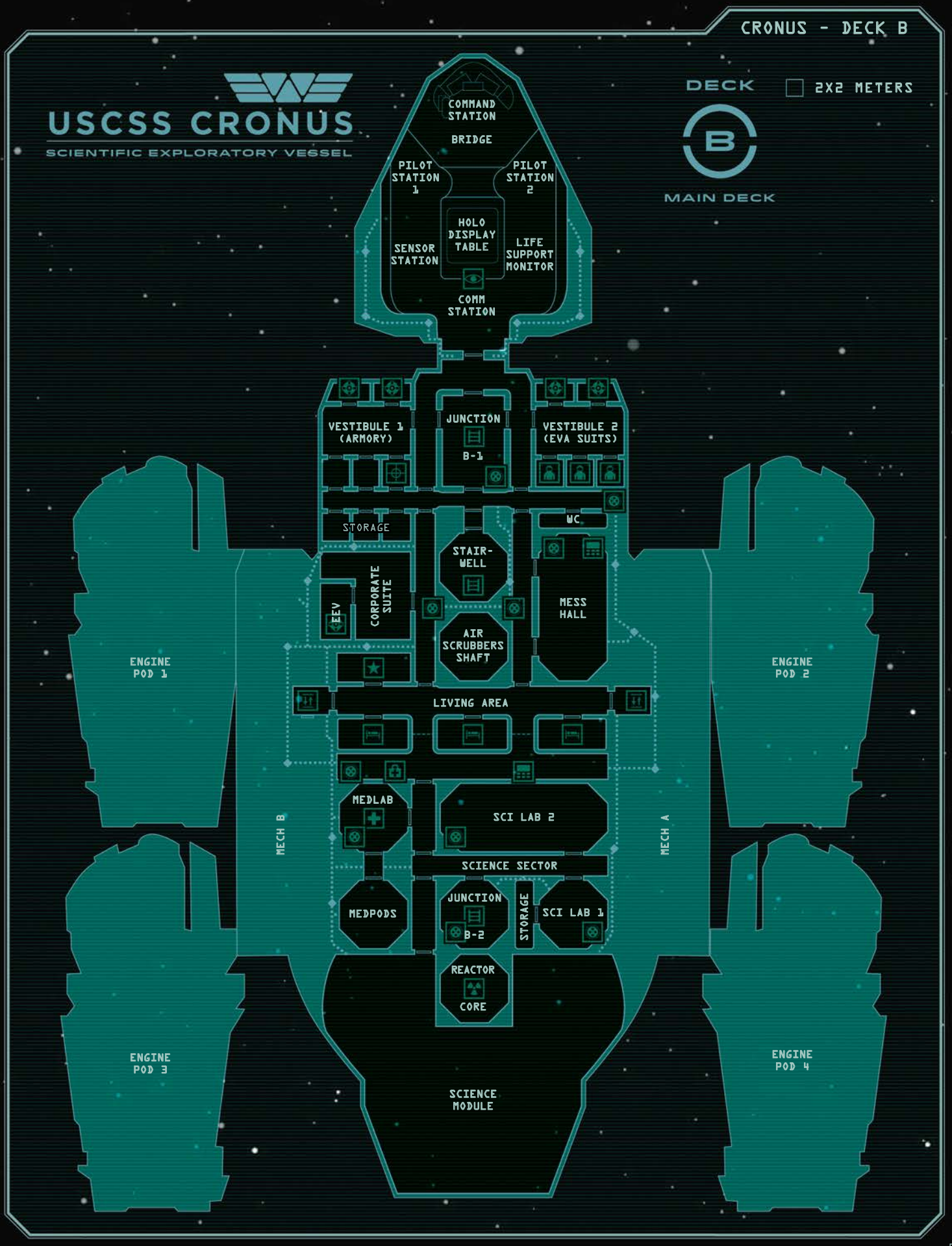
POWER PLANT: Nuclear fission generators

SENSOR SYSTEMS: Various comm antennas

NAVIGATION SYSTEMS: Independent advanced navigation systems

CREW: 17

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PRODUCTION INFORMATION

MANUFACTURER: Weyland Corp

CLASS: Heliades-Class

PRODUCT LINE: Weyland FTL ships

REG: 142601

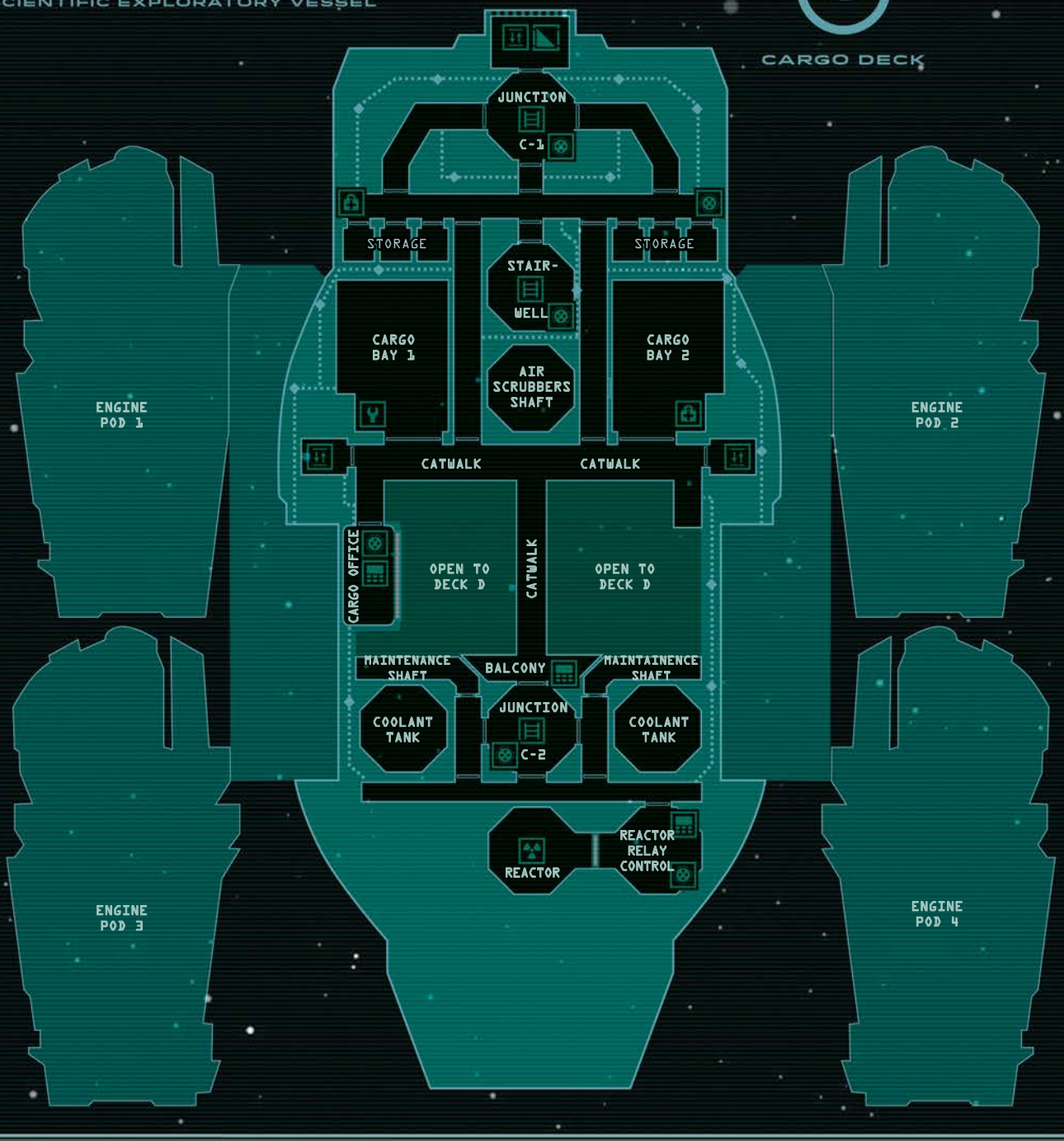
MODEL: Heavy Exploration/
Prospecting Vessel

CRONUS - DECK C

USCSS CRONUS
SCIENTIFIC EXPLORATORY VESSEL

DECK C
CARGO DECK

2X2 METERS



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MAP LEGEND

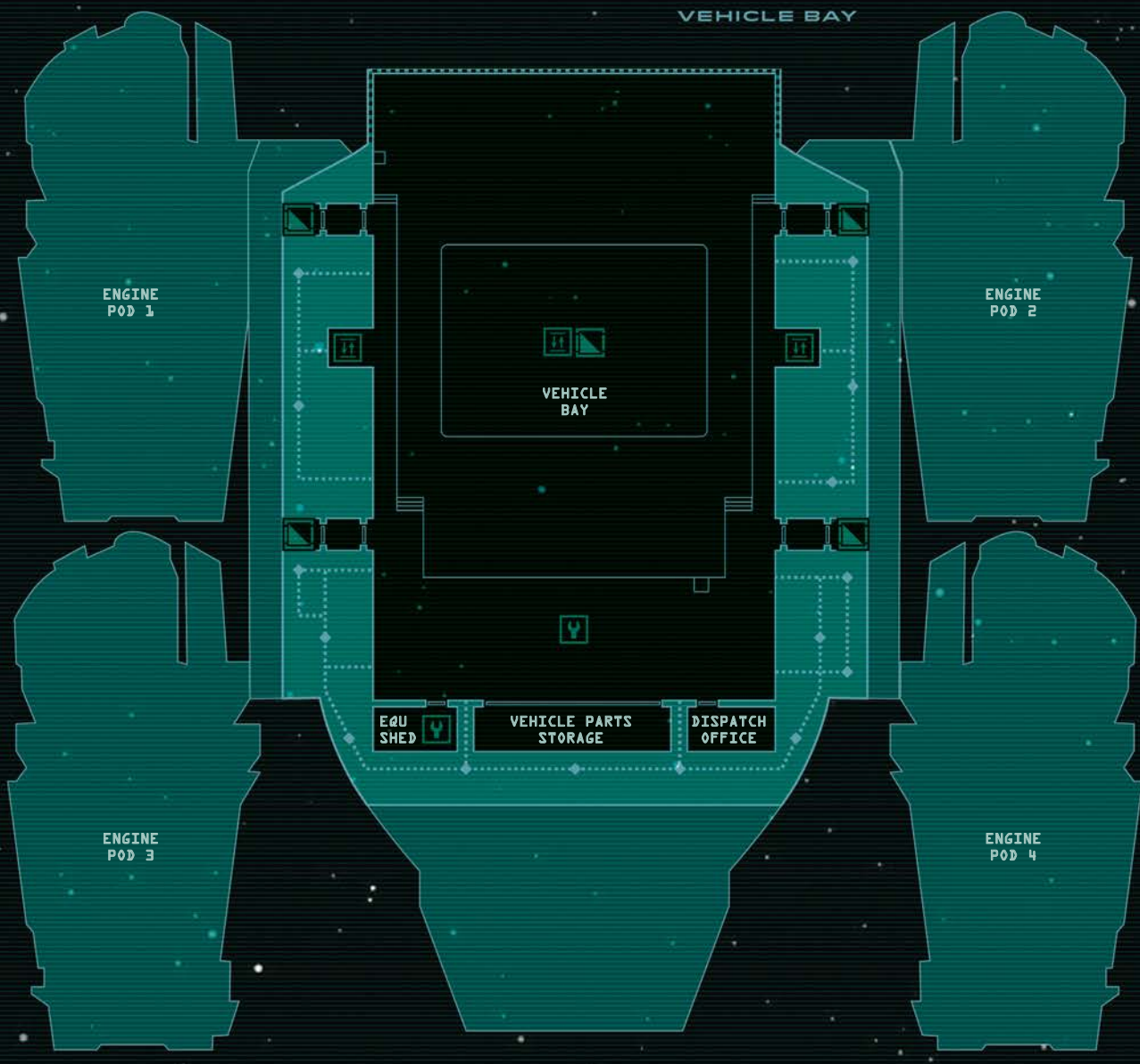
- AIRLOCK
- WORKSHOP/ENGINEERING
- BARRACKS
- ARMORY
- LADDER ACCESS
- INTERCOM
- CPT'S QUARTERS
- ELEVATOR
- EVA SUIT STORAGE
- ACCESS TERMINAL
- MAINFRAME
- OBSERVATION
- MEDKIT
- CRYOSLEEP PODS
- MEDLAB
- VENT PATHWAY
- ESCAPE POD
- RADIOACTIVE AREA

CRONUS - DECK D

USCSS CRONUS
SCIENTIFIC EXPLORATORY VESSEL

DECK D
VEHICLE BAY

2X2 METERS



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DECK A

CRYO DECK

MAIN AIRLOCK, JUNCTION A-1: The main airlock is the only point of entry to the *Cronus* and it is located on the dorsal side of the ship. The outer airlock door is damaged and seems buckled from the inside, something that the PCs notice if they spacewalk to it or try to connect the *Montero*'s passageway umbilical.

To open the outer airlock door requires a cutting torch and a **HEAVY MACHINERY** roll. Inside, a ladder leads down into the main airlock junction, down to decks B and C. Covered in scuff and scratch marks on the inside, the door does not close again once opened. After breaching the buckled door, the PCs must connect the *Montero*'s passageway umbilical to the *Cronus* and pressurize it before opening the inner airlock door. If the umbilical is damaged, the airlock suffers explosive decompression (see page 73 of the rulebook). The other airlock doors operate properly.

Anyone taking an environmental reading finds the air stiflingly stale and the temperature below freezing (see boxed text to the right).

MU/TH/UR 2000 MAINFRAME: Located directly above the bridge, this small room is accessible from the main airlock at Junction A-1. This protected area can only be entered if one has the correct command sequence or the emergency access key—things only Wilson, Johns and Cooper possess at the beginning of the scenario. Inside this spotlessly clean room is a blinking data server and a single terminal which the highest-ranking member of a crew can use to interface directly with MU/TH/UR. Clever PCs can use the computer to ask the right questions and the GM can feed them information as she so chooses.

AIR SCRUBBERS: This large shaft is only accessible via the ventilation and maintenance shafts. When operational, massive carbon filters clean the air of pollutants while churning machines electrolyze the water and generate oxygen. Powered by a direct feed from the reactors, the shaft terminates in a water-filled chamber on Deck C. Condensation accumulates at the top of the shaft and rains down here.

When the PCs arrive, the oxygen generation is offline. The shaft is dark and the water at the bottom of the shaft is frozen. Once MU/TH/UR 2000 goes online and power is restored, the air scrubbers are activated and the ice melts. This chamber then becomes very noisy and it is difficult to hear anything—all **OBSERVATION** rolls get a –2 modification in here.

The air scrubbers work via electrolysis—electrical current is channeled through submerged rods and applied to the water, causing the separation of hydrogen and oxygen. That means that there is a real risk of electrocution in here once the power is back on. Any failed skill roll in here results in an immediate attack rolled with six Base Dice and Damage 1.

The carbon filters on the air scrubbers are caked with decades of grime and mold, and just restoring power won't be enough to return them to working order. The carbon filters need to either be replaced or cleaned in order for the air circulating on the ship to return to proper oxygen levels. This requires a Shift of work and a successful **HEAVY MACHINERY** roll. Only one PC can roll, but others can help.

If the PCs actively examine the carbon filters before they get to work, they spot Neomorphic Egg Sacs growing on them (see page 39). If these are disturbed, Neomorphic Motes are released throughout the ship. The only way for the PCs to destroy the egg sacs is to burn them, something that Ava 6 can explain.

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ELEVATORS: These elevators provide access to the vehicle bay in the *Cronus*'s belly. Elevator 1 functions just fine once power is restored, although there was definitely a firefight within it at one point. Buckshot and dried blood pepper the elevator's interior. Elevator 2 is a different story—the shaft doors are ajar and the elevator is crumpled on the vehicle bay level. It looks like someone had thrown an incendiary grenade or two at it after it fell, just for good measure.

CRYO CHAMBERS: The main door into this area has claw marks around the edges of the doorway, as if something was trying to scratch its way in. The door is locked from the inside and a **HEAVY MACHINERY** roll is required to open it. The cryo beds in the chambers are covered in frost. Inside them is the sleeping crew of the *Cronus*—at least the survivors of the crew. Most of the hypersleep chambers are vacant. Two are filled with desiccated corpses, mummified by the decades in dry air. As the life support systems come online, the crew wakes up (see page 28). In lockers in this room, the personal gear of the *Cronus* crew is stored.

EXAMINATION ROOM: The examination room is a mess. There are two personal medkits here (see page 100 of the ruiebook).

SHOWERS: The showers are filthy, and some Neomorphic egg sacs are growing in the shower drains. Caution is advised.

JUNCTION A-2: This shaft leads to the other levels of the ship.

EVA STORAGE 1 AND 2: There are a total of three remaining space suits here, all older models of the IRC Mk.50 Compression Suit. They have not been tampered with and function fine.

ENVIRONMENT ON THE CRONUS

COLD: When the PCs arrive, the interior of the *Cronus* is in a deep freeze. If the PCs open their suits before the life support systems are brought online by MU/TH/UR 2000 (see Events), they will become Freezing and need to make STAMINA rolls against the cold once per Turn.

DARK: Until MU/TH/UR 2000 comes online, the interior is lit only by weak emergency lights (all zones on the ship count as dark, see page 49 of the rulebook).

AIR: In addition, the air in the *Cronus* is stale with a high concentration of carbon dioxide. All STAMINA rolls are at –2 until the air scrubbers have been fixed (see page 18).

GRAVITY: The artificial gravity on board still works.

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DECK

B MAIN DECK

ARMORY: Stripped almost bare, this room has a single Weyland Storm Rifle (stats like the M41A Pulse Rifle but *heavy*) with one reload. A case of shotgun shells (one reload left) lies on the floor. Aside from a splatter of dried milky-white spray on the wall, the room is clean. The spray is synthetic blood. It was left there by Ava from an encounter she had with an Abomination many years earlier. There is no danger in this room.

JUNCTION B-1: The ladder is undamaged and all doors at this junction work.

VESTIBULES: Adjacent to Junction B-1 are two bays for class A individual escape pods embedded in the outer hull wall. All of the pods are missing (the only escape pod still remaining is in Clayton's corporate suite, below.) If the PCs are tense and power has yet to be restored, they might mistake the two bulky, empty, red-armored EVA suits (equivalent to Eco All-Worlds Survival Suits, see page 92 of the rulebook) standing in the shadows for lurking stalkers. Opening fire here is a bad idea, as it could compromise the hull.

BRIDGE: Until power is restored, the bridge is on battery reserve and is otherwise shut down; only faint standby illumination gives off an eerie orange glow. The blast shutters are still lowered, shut tight around the viewports. There is soot on the ceiling and several of the stations are burned out.

- **COMMAND STATION:** Once power is up, the command station works like a charm. Located under a flip-up access panel on one of the treadmill arms of the captain's station is a small compartment that houses MU/TH/UR 2000's emergency access key. The glass panel that it typically lies behind is shattered, the key missing. The captain's station monitors all relevant "at a glance" information from other consoles. If the PCs access the command station and make a **COMTECH** roll, they can find information on where the *Cronus* has been: on a distant, uncharted planet in the 26 Draconis system.
- **HOLOGRAPHIC DISPLAY TABLE:** This station was once state-of-the-art hologram technology, but it's now slagged, burnt out by a fire on the bridge. It is damaged beyond repair.
- **SENSOR STATION:** This station was also damaged by the fire but can be repaired to working order with a Shift of work and a **COMTECH** roll. The damaged sensors sporadically pick up a sensor ghost (see the Sensor Ghost Redux event).
- **LIFE SUPPORT MONITORS:** When power is restored to this station, the monitors flash red. The carbon dioxide content in the ship's recycled air is high—maintenance must be performed on the air scrubbers. The carbon filters in the Oxygen Generation System must be replaced (see page 30). If a PC manages to talk to MU/TH/UR before power to this terminal is restored, she shares the same information.
- **PILOT STATIONS:** Someone has taken an axe to Station 1, and in fact has left it embedded in the console. While it looks untouched, Station 2 is also dead—something that is not evident until power is restored. It's possible to open up some of the deck plating and try to reconnect power (requires one Shift of work and a successful **HEAVY MACHINERY** roll), but an easier solution would be to cannibalize Station 2's parts to reactivate Station 1 (also one Shift of work, but a **COMTECH** roll at +2). Only one pilot station is needed to fly the ship.

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DOORS ON THE CRONUS

All doors on the *Cronus* can be opened by the push of a button, unless stated otherwise in the room descriptions. Some doors can only be opened by MU/TH/UR 2000 or by using an encrypted key card—Wilson and Clayton carry one each, and one can be found in Science Lab 1, dropped by Ava.

DECOMPRESSION: The outer hull of the *Cronus* has Armor Rating 6. Shots that miss the target in a compartment next to an exterior bulkhead risk rupturing the hull and causing explosive decompression (see page 73 of the rulebook). If this occurs, all doors and vents to the compartment are automatically and permanently sealed after one Round.

CREW QUARTERS: All of these rooms are either locked tight, ransacked, or smell like death. Random personal items of worth can be found in them, but the *Cronus* crew won't be pleased if they discover the PCs have been looting their possessions.

MESS HALL: Food stores were ravaged—it looks like a pack of rabid raccoons have been through here. Most of the exposed food stores are rotten and covered in mold. Someone had been making origami animals out of metallic paper, setting them up around the room. The origami animals are a product of the android Ava's deranged state. While there is mold everywhere, none of it is of the Neomorphic variety. The mess was scavenged and ransacked by the Abominations long ago.

CORPORATE SUITE: Clayton's wardroom and quarters, this spacious area was at one point luxurious. The bed is soaked with blood, the couch cushion stuffing is all torn out, and the furniture in the room is destroyed.

- **DRUGS:** Under the mattress is a pack of illegal stimulants that are to be injected into the ocular cavity. Reduces **STRESS LEVEL** to zero. D6 doses.
- **WALL SAFE:** Built into the wall and only accessible via Clayton's codes, the safe contains an encrypted Modular Computing Device. This cube contains all the data on the science mission to LV-1113. There is also one million dollars-worth of rare cash bills. Without the code, the safe needs to be cracked (requires a Shift of work and a –3 **COMTECH** roll), or the door needs to be blown, requiring an explosion with Blast Power of 12 or more—which damages the cube and destroys most of the cash.
- **WETBAR:** The bar here was practically cleaved in two. It is splintered and wrecked, as are most of the bottles stored here. Only a few bottles remain intact, scattered haphazardly across the floor.
- **WALK-IN CLOSET/ESCAPE POD:** Anyone examining this closet realizes that what appears to be a walk-in closet door is in actuality the entry into an EEV—the only one on the ship. It is functional, but can only be accessed with Clayton's codes. The escape pod has only three cryopods in it and it's not FTL capable.

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MED LAB: Within this room are two older-generation Pauling Medpods (see page 100 of the rulebook). One has its plexiglass tube splintered and shattered as if something broke out of it. The other is sealed and lit from within, but the entire inner surface of the plexiglass is covered in thick dried blood. There is a row of large specimen jars. Floating within two of them are two small alien creatures (Bloodbursters, see page 40).

On a far shelf is a smaller specimen jar without liquid, containing the same fungal nodes (Neomorphic Egg Sacs) that can be found in various areas of the ship. On the desk next to that is an open metallic urn. Four organic-looking glass vials are inside the urn—three of those are intact with some kind of black liquid within them, while the fourth is cracked open and empty.

- **VIALS:** If a PC decides to take a vial with them, they had best keep it in cold storage. If it starts to sweat, it releases its contents and begins to affect the PCs (see next page).
- **THE CURE:** Under the desk is a medkit case that contains six syringes full of the 26 Draconis Strain derivative, a "cure" for those infected by Neomorphic Motes (see page 39).
- **BLOODBURSTERS:** The two Bloodbursters in the jars are dead, but the PCs don't need to realize that at first. They were surgically removed from their victims by the medpods. Both those infected and the embryonic Neomorphs were killed in the process. The medpods were included on this mission specifically for operating on and removing parasitic organisms.
- **MOTES:** If anyone disturbs the egg sac nodes within the sealed jars, motes eject from them and attempt to find a way out, eventually settling down and dying from lack of a host. However, if the container is broken or opened in some way, the motes spread throughout the ship.
- **MEDPOD:** The broken medpod works (**MEDICAL AID** +3), but any PC who uses it risks sepsis because of the unsanitary environment (roll for a disease with Virulence 6, see page 75 of the rulebook). If a PC is morbidly curious and opens the bloody medpod, they find the remains of a Stage IV Abomination within. Locked in the device to be vivisected, the former crew member's lower torso has been dissected, and his soft elongated skull has been opened and picked at. Data gathered from the exploratory surgery can be accessed using the medical computer at the desk. While he appears dead, the decades-old Abomination has one last gasp in him, which he uses to savagely attack the closest PC. With its brain exposed, however, the dreadful thing is easy enough to kill (only 3 Health left and no Armor Rating).
- **MEDS AND DRUGS:** Four personal medkits, surgical instruments, and D6 doses each of Neversleep Pills, Hydr8tion, and Naproleve can all be found in the cabinets here.

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SCIENCE LAB 1: The lights in this room flicker, and the stench of decay is overwhelming. There is a pile of gnawed bones in the room. The main lab has an enclosed decontamination area on the main examination table—and under the de-con hood is a perfectly preserved metallic urn. A malfunctioning deep cold freezer with a smashed glass door has four more of these urns in it. An ooze has seeped out of them, forming congealed pools on the floor. Strange, black fungal nodes are growing on the urns and in the pools.

- **BONES:** A Medic or Scientist who examines the bones realizes that they are not all human. There are Neomorph and Abomination bones mixed in as well. This room was the nest of an adult Neomorph. If you use the "Hunter and Prey" event, this Neomorph is still around and could attack at any time.
- **URNS:** These, of course, are the Engineer Ampules that contain the black liquid 26 Draconis Strain of Agent A0-3959X.91–15. Ingestion of the pure form of the agent has fatal results (it counts as a Virulence 12 disease). Each urn is a regular item in terms of encumbrance.
- **FUNGAL NODES:** These are in fact Neomorphic Egg Sacs, ready to eject Motes and infect any PC or NPC with exposed orifices of any kind (see page 39). A PC examining the room learns that the nodes are underfoot throughout the room, and difficult to avoid. Moving through the room without disturbing the egg sacs requires a **MOBILITY** roll.
- **KEY CARD:** Sitting half-submerged in a pool of black goo on the floor is the emergency key card access to the MU/TH/UR mainframe room on the *Cronus*—dropped here by Ava during a scuffle with the Neomorphs. The key card is a Tiny item.

SCIENCE LAB 2: This is a charred shell of a room—whatever happened here, the crew ended it real quick with the liberal use of an incinerator or two. There's the burnt-out, partial remains of a drum of some kind in the room, and a body buried in the debris, its arms shriveled up and clutching at its chest. The stale air is thick with the smell of burnt rubber, plastic, and flesh.

There is nothing worthwhile in here—save for the discovery that the body is not quite human. It is the remains of a Stage IV Abomination, its gelatinous cowl boiled away and its features obscured by charring. The one giveaway that it is something inhuman is the length of its forearms, something any Scientist can confirm using the **ANALYZE** talent. The drum was previously filled with quinitricetyline from Deck C (below).

JUNCTION B-2: This junction works fine and allows access from Decks A-C as well as the ventilation and maintenance shafts.

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DECK

C CARGO DECK

JUNCTION C-1: Junction 1 begins at the main airlock and terminates here. The external airlock door is sabotaged, but the internal doors work fine. The *Cronus* has an external elevator attached to this airlock, similar to the one on the *Nostromo*. It lowers a crew to the surface of a planet if they choose not to use the vehicle bay. Currently, it is out of order.

STORAGE UNITS: These units contain various ship supplies and tools, in addition to the following:

- **STERILIZATION PROTOCOL:** One of them contains seven drums of the highly unstable napalm like chemical quinitricetyline, brought along in case things got out of hand on LV-1113. Lighting up a drum of quinitricetyline (one item) will trigger an explosion with Blast Power 12, followed by an Intensity 12 fire.
- **CLAYTON'S SECRET STASH:** This unit requires a code to gain access to it, and is full of two dozen Engineer urns taken from LV-1113, each containing four vials of Agent A0-3959X.91-15.
- **TOOLS:** Two bolt guns, a cutting torch, and a maintenance jack can also be found here. See Chapter 6 for more on these.

CARGO BAYS: These cargo maws are pitch black inside and even restoring the power will not activate their lights. Inside, the rattling of chains can be heard, likely pulled slack from holding cargo crates in place. A winch in each room pulls the chains tight and secures the cargo safely.

- Bay 1 is filled with food stores that are untouched.
- Bay 2 is mostly empty save for spare RV tires.

CATWALK: The catwalk overlooks the vehicle bay. A crane on ceiling tracks loads cargo to and from the vehicle bay and the cargo deck. Aside from directly in front of the cargo bay doors, the catwalk has a railing on either side, and the only way to reach the Technical section from this deck is to cross it.

CARGO OFFICE: The cargo crane is operated from this room. It has a viewport overlooking the vehicle bay.

JUNCTION C-2: Another relatively safe junction with functioning doors. Nothing to see here.

COOLANT TANKS: These help keep the engines from overloading. If sabotaged, the reactor begins building to critical mass—but it would take something very drastic and inventive to destroy the ship in this way. They aren't accessible except via service tunnels.

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REACTOR RELAY AND CONTROL: The only lighting here comes from an open access port on the reactor relay. It glows a dull, pale blue, casting long and deep shadows. Something tore up the furniture and loose equipment to build a bizarre nest here. In the pile of debris near the reactor lies a crumpled-up spacesuit—its filthy helmet is mostly fogged and the tattered suit looks like it was set on fire at one point.

- **CLEANING UP:** There is some kind of yellow-white resin covering most of the reaction chamber, and it needs to be removed in order to bring the engines on line. While cleaning up the control room restores the reactor relay (no roll needed), repairs still need to be made on the outside of the ship to reconnect the relay to the four fission engines themselves (**HEAVY MACHINERY** roll and three Turns of work). The power generated by the ship's four engine pods channels through the main relay here before being distributed to the rest of the ship.
- **THE ABOMINATION:** The yellow-white residue is dried Neomorph blood. The "spacesuit" is actually a Stage IV Abomination, sitting contorted with its limbs folded up over its torso. The "helmet" is, in fact, its bulbous head. It has been holed up and hibernating here for decades, huddled by the reactor. The Abomination is passive (see page 51 of the rulebook) and if the PCs move quietly in here (**MOBILITY** roll), they can avoid waking the Abomination up. If they start cleaning the room, they awaken it immediately. If the PCs flee, the Abomination starts stalking them on the ship.
- **RADIATION:** Due to reactor leaks, the entire room is covered by strong radiation (1 Rad per Turn, see page 76 of the rulebook). Firing weapons in the reactor room is dangerous—it can cause a critical build up in the engines. For any shot with a firearm in here that misses its target, roll a Stress Die. A roll of  causes critical damage to the reactor relay and triggers the total destruction of the *Cronus* after ten minutes (Mother starts counting down). The damage can be repaired with a Turn of work and a **HEAVY MACHINERY** roll.
- **SELF-DESTRUCT:** The ship's emergency destruct system—which involves shutting off the cooling unit so that the reactor builds towards critical mass—is also located in this room. Once activated (with a **COMTECH** roll and a Turn of work), the reactor begins a ten-minute countdown to overload. Stopping the countdown requires another **COMTECH** roll, but can be done in a single Round. After five minutes (another Turn), the process is irreversible.

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DECK

D VEHICLE BAY

GARAGE: Most of the vehicle compliment of the *Cronus* is missing—there are only two ATVs aboard and no RTVs. Both ATVs are lying on their sides haphazardly—it's clear they weren't secured before takeoff. Looking up, visitors can see the catwalk and loading crane above on Deck C. Deep shadows are cast everywhere—there are many places to hide.

The bay is the least affected area on the ship—it's just dusty from disuse and settled debris. The Dispatch Office, Equipment Shed, and Parts Storage are clear of danger and contain whatever reasonable tools the PCs might require.

- **GARAGE DOOR:** This opens like a ramp for easy vehicle egress, but the locks must be taken care of first. The bay must be decompressed before opening it while in space, or everything will blow out.
- **AIRLOCKS:** All four airlocks on this level have been sabotaged and cannot work without massive repairs. ■

EVENTS

The following section contains events that you can spring on the players, divided into Act I, II, and III. These events don't all need to occur, and they don't need to occur in the order listed. Instead, see the events as an arsenal of drama for you to use as you see fit. Some events are mandatory however—these are clearly indicated as such.

Remember to also give the players new Personal Agendas at the start of each Act.

DON'T RUSH IT

When the PCs enter the *Cronus*, don't bombard them with events right away. Instead, work on building the atmosphere as they explore the derelict. There is plenty to discover! Only when you feel the need to up the tempo should you start using the events.

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ACT I: PANDORA'S BOX

Eager to be done with this run and collect a paycheck, the crew of the *Montero* wakes up to prep the ship for unloading. First, they gather in the galley to eat. Use this time to have the players introduce their PCs to each other. For the first Shift, all PCs count as Dehydrated (see page 72 of the rulebook) due to the effects of hypersleep. As the PCs go about their duties, they begin to notice that things aren't quite right. Suggested events:

PING: Suddenly, MU/TH/UR/6500 reports an approaching ship—perhaps a colonial picket ship protecting Sutter's World, or a cargo inspector—when there is none. A sensor diagnosis (**COMTECH** roll) leads to the conclusion that it was a sensor malfunction and nothing more.

NOBODY'S HOME (MANDATORY): Sutter's World doesn't respond to any hails, and there's no return ping from their beacon tower. That's because the *Montero* is nowhere near the colony, and is instead in deep space. Navigation star charts are off, and another **COMTECH** roll has the PCs determine they are nowhere near Sutter's World. Instead, they are in deep space between stars.

NEW ORDERS (MANDATORY): MU/TH/UR 6500 signals that she wants to talk to Captain Miller. She informs her that they have picked up a distress call from an unknown ship and need to investigate. The mysterious transmission is too garbled for the PCs to determine who sent it. The crew needs to triangulate its location and trace it to its source. The captain must stop the crew from their preparations and explain to them what is going on. As company rules say the PCs need to investigate, not doing so means they will forfeit their shares and get no money for the run.

BRACE FOR IMPACT: Suddenly, the sensors detect a ship approaching on a collision course with the *Montero*. Mother warns of imminent impact. Klaxons on the bridge rage as warning lights flash red. A small area without stars grows closer and closer. The PCs realize it's a derelict ship without any running lights or beacons. "Brace for collision," Mother drones. The pilot needs to make a **PILOTING** check at –2 to avoid a collision. Failure means severe damage to the *Montero*, crippling her FTL drive and causing explosive decompression in some sections of the ship. Repairs take at least 18 hours (three Shifts). The crew are unharmed though.

GHOST SHIP (MANDATORY): Mother informs the crew that the ghost ship was the source of the distress call. Her engines dead, inertia has carried the derelict along at her last achieved speed of .04 light speed. With no running and interior lights on the ghost ship, the PCs can't identify her until they come about and catch up to her.

Coming alongside the ghost ship and kicking on the floods, what they see is something out of the history books—it's the USCSS *Cronus*, a Weyland SEV M3 Heliades-class spacecraft. Launched in 2110, it's been missing for three quarters of a century. She is running on minimal power with all exterior and interior lights off. The only sign of life from her is the repeating SOS signal. Show the players the cover image of this booklet. Mother informs the crew that a salvage operation is mandated by company rules. These are their priorities:

1. Recover scientific data and samples from the USCSS *Cronus*.
2. Escort the salvaged *Cronus* to Anchorhead or another W-Y facility.
3. Save crew members on the *Cronus*.

Mother also provides floor plans of the *Cronus* for the boarding action. Give the players the deck plans in the center of this booklet.

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BOARDING PARTY (MANDATORY): The PCs must match the ship's speed and course and attempt to board her (**PILOTING** roll for the pilot—a failed roll will cause further damage to the *Montero* but nothing critical). Spacewalking (**MOBILITY** roll) or attempting to extend an umbilical extension between the two ships (**HEAVY MACHINERY** roll), the PCs discover that the main airlock of the *Cronus* is damaged. The players need to decide if all PCs go into the *Cronus* or if someone remains behind.

Once the boarding party enters the derelict ship, enter stealth mode (see page 51 of the rulebook) and don't forget to roll for air supply after each Turn. Use the map of the *Cronus* and the location descriptions on page 14 and onward. Let the PCs explore freely.

THE HEADLESS MAN: The PCs come across the slumped-over, headless body of a man in a spacesuit. There is a splatter of blood and brain matter on the wall behind him, and a Model 37A2 shotgun lies next to him. A casual examination shows that something isn't quite right about him. His arms seem a little too long and have stretched his compression suit until it has torn at the forearms.

STRESS LEVEL +1 for all PCs present. The man was actually a Stage II Abomination (see page 43) with enough of his wits about him to take his own life. There are some extra shotgun shells (enough for one reload) in an open zipper pocket on his compression suit, and some still in the weapon itself.

I'VE GOT MOVEMENT: If the PCs use motion trackers, they detect movement within the corridors of the *Cronus*, some zones away. The blips disappear before the PCs manage to track down the source. **STRESS LEVEL** +1 for all PCs present. The source of the signals is either the damaged android Ava, suffering some memory damage and wandering the ship aimlessly, or an adult Neomorph that has been awakened from hibernation by the PCs' entry, or both. The PCs will encounter them later.

EGG SACS AFOOT: The PCs come across an area with Neomorphic Egg Sacs (see page 39), in addition to the ones listed in the room descriptions. As long as the PCs wear their suits, they're fine. A Scientist can use the Analysis talent on the egg sacs to learn more.

HUNTER AND PREY: An adult Neomorph (see page 41) hibernating on the *Cronus* is awakened by the PCs arrival, and starts to stalk them. It could attack at any time. This event can also occur during Act II or Act III.

SENSOR GHOST REDUX: If the PCs repair the sensor station on the bridge, it emits occasional pings to alert of a nearby ship that doesn't appear to exist. This event can occur in Act II as well, and comes into play in Act III. The ping is from the *Sotillo*, but the PCs cannot learn this now.

MOTHER AWAKES (MANDATORY): Suddenly, the MU/TH/UR 2000 mainframe on the *Cronus* comes online and powers up the reactor and the life support systems, as a reaction to the PCs' presence on board. The temperature increases and more lights activate. The PCs also notice a haze of vapor as warmer air begins filling the corridors. After a few Turns, the effects of cold and darkness (see pages 73 and 49 of the rulebook) are removed. The air scrubbers (see page 18) also activate, creating quite a bit of noise but no fresh air, as the carbon filters need repairs.

SLEEP OF AGES (MANDATORY): As a result of the life support systems coming online, the sleeping crew of the *Cronus* wake from their hypersleep in the cryochambers. This is declared by MU/TH/UR 2000, her voice droning "Warning, cryochambers deactivated." The process takes a few Turns. The survivors consist of the ship's XO Johns, Sgt. Reid, Drs. Cooper and Flynn, and Company Rep Clayton. When they wake up, they suffer amnesia and acute disorientation from the long time in stasis. Dr. Cooper, for one, complains of headaches. They clearly need medical attention, each requiring a **MEDICAL AID** roll to start recovering, preferably in the Medlab if the PCs clean it up.

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MOTHER OF ALL MIGRAINES (MANDATORY): Soon after waking up, Dr. Cooper begins complaining of migraines. Before long, he stops speaking coherently, instead muttering nonsense. A Bloodburster spore grows in his skull like a tumor, converting the cells of his brain into its own rapidly gestating body. As it grows, the creature essentially lobotomizes Cooper from the inside out. When his seizures reach a crescendo, the Bloodburster is born. If you like, use the boxed text below to describe the harrowing scene. All PCs present must make an immediate Panic Roll.

Aggressive, the infant Neomorph immediately attacks the nearest PC. For Bloodburster stats, see page 40. As soon as it suffers any damage, or when the signature attack list so indicates, the Bloodburster flees into the nearest air duct. As it makes its escape, it rapidly grows, returning after just a few Turns to stalk the PCs as a fully grown Neomorph. Play this out using the rules for stealth mode. Any PCs who are killed can be replaced by crew from the *Cronus*.

GETTING OUT OF DODGE? If the PCs want to leave the *Cronus*, MU/TH/UR 6500 triggers the destruction of the *Montero* under Special Order 966 from Weyland-Yutani. See the event "T-Minus Ten Minutes" below.

THE BLOODBURSTER IS BORN

Blood seeps out of Cooper's nose and ears. Bloody eyes roll over white as the scientist convulses and writhes against the wall. As you and your crew rush to hold the man down, you notice that the Cronus crew back away instead. Busy trying to help the convulsing scientist, you don't stop to ask them why. In the depths of a seizure now, Cooper flails about at everything and everyone.

With a sickening pop and a bloody splash, his eyeball launches from his face and smacks into [insert PC name] before bouncing across the floor and rolling under a cryotube. This time, you pause, trying to process exactly what it is you are seeing. A slender, gore-covered arm pushes its way out of Cooper's empty eye socket, reaches around, and tugs at his distended mouth. As spindly white fingers yank his teeth back, Cooper does not scream—it's clear that he isn't in his own head anymore. Something else is, and it wants out.

Flesh tears and tendons snap as the thing inside his splintering skull pulls his face open right at the jawline. Finally, a thick gurgling sound wells up inside Cooper as his head is ripped from his body, his neck gushing as whatever was inside him plops to the floor in a burst of blood.

"Kill it! Kill it now!" someone yells. The translucent-white thing on the floor sloughs off its placenta, struggling to stand on all four wobbly, fawn-like legs. Shaking brain matter from its spiky hide, the Bloodburster turns its bulbous, eyeless head towards you and crouches.



STAGE IV – JUVENILE NEOMORPH

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ACT II: THE LONG NIGHT

Having defeated the Neomorph (or still being stalked by it), the PCs get a chance to catch their breath and start planning their way home—only to realize there are other dangers lurking about. Suggested events:

PARTIAL TRUTHS (MANDATORY): Having recovered his senses after the long hypersleep, Johns tells the PCs that they set down on LV-1113 and explored some ancient ruins—to which Clayton quickly interjects that it was an archeological mission. Their science team collected important artifacts (the ampules in the science lab) and inadvertently brought back spores with them that infected some of the crew with Neomorphic Motes. Johns also knows about the egg sacs and the danger they pose.

The doctors on the science team came up with a cure that neutralizes the Neomorphic growth and turns it into an inert tumor. They inoculated everyone, so Johns is confused. A search of Cooper's pockets reveals his still-full syringe—he never used it.

If any of the PCs removed their compression suits—likely, as their air supply has probably run out by now—Dr. Flynn suggests that they be inoculated immediately, as they have probably been infected by the Neomorphic Motes. One PC can use Cooper's dose, and there are other prepared doses in the Medlab, possibly prompting a trip there to retrieve it. If they do decide to go, Dr. Flynn wants to go with them to retrieve one of the "artifacts" that was left there (the full ampule or one of the vials).

BAD AIR: Aboard the *Cronus*, everyone has trouble taking deep breaths—the air there is stale and heavy in carbon dioxide (see page 19). Johns tells them that after decades of disuse, the air scrubbers probably need their filters replaced in the central air scrubber shaft.

T-MINUS TEN MINUTES (MANDATORY): This event can occur in Act I if the players decide to abandon the *Cronus* before they find her crew, or even if they refuse to examine the ship in the first place. The PCs' comm units crackle to life with a burst of static. It's Mother, contacting them directly from the *Montero*. "Displacement Drive malfunction," she drones. "Cascade failure imminent. Fission reactor overload in T-minus ten minutes." **STRESS LEVEL** +1 for all PCs.

Mother continues to remind the PCs at one-minute increments, until there are 30 seconds left, at which point she counts down to 0. This culminates with the total destruction of the *Montero* in a huge explosion. There is no way to stop it, although the PCs could try. You don't need to play this out Round by Round, but ask the players what they want to do and keep counting down at regular intervals to keep the pressure up.

If they head back to the *Montero* and ask MU/TH/UR 6500 to stop the countdown, she refuses, even if ordered by Wilson. A successful **COMTECH** roll in the *Montero*'s reactor control confirms that the destruction of the ship cannot be stopped, and reveals that the countdown seems to have been triggered intentionally. The truth is that MU/TH/UR 6500 has triggered the countdown herself, following Special Order 966 to ensure that the *Cronus* is brought back to Weyland-Yutani.

The players should realize that their only chance to survive is for all to board the *Cronus*, and to get as far away as possible from the *Montero* before she detonates. If they don't realize this by themselves, have an NPC point it out. The engines of the *Cronus* are still offline, so the only way to reach safe distance is to set the *Montero* on a course far away from the *Cronus*.

Either a PC must sacrifice themself, or the pilot can set the *Montero* on autopilot and use the ancient cargo shuttle *Daisy* to get back to the *Cronus*. Either way, have the pilot plotting the course for the *Montero* make a hard (–2) **PILOTING** roll. If it fails, the ship doesn't reach safe distance from the *Cronus* and the massive explosion causes explosive decompression in D6 compartments on the *Cronus*. Decide which as you see fit—you can have it happen to areas where PCs or NPCs are located, for extra drama.

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BREAKING LOOSE: If the *Cronus* and the *Montero* are connected by the passageway umbilical, there is a problem decoupling it. As Mother's countdown continues, the PCs struggle to get the ships disconnected. This can be done with a cutting torch and a **HEAVY MACHINERY** roll, or by a **STRENGTH** roll. Other PCs can help. If all rolls fail, the *Cronus* may break loose using the power of its engines, but this causes structural damage to the ship.

NO MONEY: During the countdown, the PCs (particularly Rye or Miller) might want to try to save at least part of their volatile yet valuable Tritium/Helium-3 shipment before the *Montero* explodes, as it's worth a lot of money. If Rye or Miller are NPCs, they insist on this.

The cargo shuttle *Daisy* can carry ten tanks. Loading her with the power loader on the *Montero* takes time. Each tank requires a **STRENGTH** or **HEAVY MACHINERY** roll (if a power loader is used). A failed roll means a tank drops—roll a Stress Die. A roll of  means that the tank explodes, destroying the *Daisy* and instantly killing everyone present in the *Montero* cargo hold.

Remember to keep counting down when dramatically appropriate. If the PCs waste time, they won't make it into the *Cronus* before the *Montero* detonates. Anyone and anything, including the *Daisy*, that is caught outside the *Cronus* when this happens suffers blast damage. For PCs, roll for this as an explosion with Blast Power 12. If the *Daisy* is caught in the blast, she is crippled and suffers total decompression—the PCs need to escape in compression suits and abandon the cargo if they want to live. **STRESS LEVEL** +1 for all PCs present.

On a tilt, the *Daisy* can be wedged into the vehicle bay of the *Cronus*, but both her control cab and thrusters will scrape the bay walls and ceiling on the way in. Have the pilot make a **PILOTING** roll. If it fails, roll one Stress Die for each tank on the Daisy. Any  rolled means a tank explodes, triggering a chain reaction that destroys the *Daisy* and kills anyone inside the cargo lifter.

CHANGE OF PLANS (MANDATORY): Once the PCs realize that the *Cronus* is their only way home, they need to fix her comm arrays, repair her engines, and get her air scrubbers running. Johns or someone else from the *Cronus* crew can inform them about this.

- **COMM ARRAY:** Repairing this requires a spacewalk, four Turns of work, and a **COMTECH** roll. Only one PC rolls, but others can help (including NPCs). A Stage IV Abomination is hibernating on the outer hull.
- **ENGINES:** Getting the engines back online requires external repairs (a spacewalk, three Turns of work and a **HEAVY MACHINERY** roll), but also requires cleaning up the reactor control room, where an Abomination hibernates (see page 25).
- **AIR SCRUBBERS:** See page 18.

During the repairs, you can spring other events on the players. For example, *Cronus* crew members can attack a PC during a spacewalk (see below).

AGGRESSIVE TENDENCIES (MANDATORY): Without warning, crew members from the *Cronus* start acting irrationally and aggressively, attacking the PCs in a violent rage. They have been infected by their inoculations. The derivative of the black liquid called 26 Draconis Strain transforms them into Stage II Abominations (see page 43).

Use these attacks for maximum dramatic effect. First only one NPC turns, attacking a PC in a violent rage without regard for their own survival and with no warning. The attacker cannot be reasoned with. Any attacked PC must make an immediate Panic Roll. Once the first attack is over, one or two more NPCs turn. They can attack head-on or just disappear and start stalking the PCs, returning later as fully developed Stage III Abominations. Don't have Clayton turn early, however, as she has a role to play in Act III.

If the PCs examine the bodies of the turned NPCs, they see the changes brought on by the black liquid. Remaining *Cronus* crew members panic, not understanding what is happening to their friends. A Scientist can **ANALYZE** the bodies to learn more about the transformation, but not the cause of it.

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ENCOUNTERING AVA: In a room or corridor on the *Cronus*, the PCs encounter the damaged android Ava. As the PCs round a corner, they notice a silhouetted body slumped against the far wall. This body is different than the other corpses they've seen aboard. Unlike the ravaged, decayed, or skeletal remains of the others, this woman is whole.

If anyone tries to lift her up, they find the back of her head slick and sticky. Expecting to pull their hand away and find it covered in blood, they instead find a milky-white substance—android blood. It is Ava, the ship's damaged and confused synthetic. She has a nasty head wound under her hair behind her right ear that can be repaired (see page 77 of the rulebook).

Once repaired, Ava offers the PCs help and information. Also, Neomorphs and Abominations are confused by androids as they smell "off" to them—if the PCs repair her and gain her trust, they can use the creatures' disregard for her to their advantage.

INFECTED: If any of the PCs took the inoculation, some of them start to turn into Abominations just like the *Cronus* crew. First, choose one PC and describe how their skin starts to itch and their head hurts as they enter Stage I of the transformation. **STRESS LEVEL** +1 for each infected PC. Of course, Lucas can't be infected. Also avoid infecting Wilson early, as he has a key role to play in Act III. Shortly after, the infected PC enters Stage II and is overcome by violent rage. (You can give the player a chance to resist the infection with a Sickness Roll against Virulence 6 if you want to play nice.)

At this point, the player gets a new Personal Agenda that overrides their current one—give the player the "Infected Agenda" card along with the card entitled "Effects of Infection." Let the player continue controlling the PC until their initial attack is resolved. Any PC attacked by another crew member must make an immediate Panic Roll.

If the infected PC survives its first attack, they become an NPC under your control. The character starts stalking the other PCs and soon turns into a Stage III Abomination (and later Stage IV). Give the player a new character to play as a PC—it can be Ava or any survivors from the *Cronus* crew.

YOU CAN'T HANDLE THE TRUTH: Ava tells the PCs the truth about the inoculations, if they haven't already figured it out. Anyone who has been administered the cure could turn into an Abomination—but they have a chance to resist. She also reveals the presence of Agent A0-3959X.91–15, which is on board. The rare "artifacts" that Clayton wants taken back are actually deadly weapons.

PLAYING ABOMINATIONS

After a PC is infected, they find themselves struggling to maintain their sanity whilst dealing with excruciating pain. A PC can fight the transformation and sometimes make it deep into Stage II before rage overtakes them. By then, they rely on instinct only, although they can sometimes be confused by something that was important to them in the past—allowing those facing them to get a chance to regroup. For example—an Abomination might find his way back home, to his quarters, or to his ship, or be distracted by a hologram of a loved one. By the time they reach Stage III, they are something different altogether—they are something ALIEN.

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ACT III: DIVIDED WE FALL

In the final Act of the scenario, the PCs need to fight for their lives in the derelict ship, facing off against the corporate agents, Lucas, and the infected crew members, without knowing who is on their side and who is transforming into an Abomination. In this Act, the Personal Agendas of the PCs play out in full—especially for Lucas and Wilson—and what happens is largely determined by the players themselves. Here are some suggested events however:

GOING HOME: Thanks to the work of the PCs and/or NPCs, the engines of the *Cronus* come back online. As soon as this happens, MU/TH/UR 2000 locks the ship on a course for Earth. A **COMTECH** roll reveals that the mainframe is under Special Order 966 to return the *Cronus* to Earth. No PC can override this order.

MEDICINAL PURPOSES: Clayton asks the PCs to help bring the strain samples to Earth, explaining that this "primeval" Xenomorph material is priceless, invaluable for research into cancer and a host of other serious diseases. And even if the 26 Draconis Strain cure is unstable, if it could be perfected, anyone encountering the spores would be safe. According to the translations the science team made, these creatures are not native to LV-1113—they could be spread over countless worlds. Let the PCs react to this. Clayton will defend herself if attacked.

MUTINY! If the PCs resist Clayton and want to destroy the 26 Draconis Strain samples or even the *Cronus* itself, Clayton tries to bribe or persuade crew members to come to her side—especially Wilson, if he's still alive—causing a mutiny among the survivors. Clayton uses **MANIPULATION** to have her way, using whatever leverage she can find.

Clayton wants to accomplish a few things. She wants to get the 26 Draconis Strain syringes from the Medlab; get cash from the safe in her suite to bribe the crew with; retrieve her MCD cube, also in the safe; finally, she wants to load as many containers of Agent A0-3959X.91–15 as she can into her quarters using the EEV as an insurance policy.

Clayton sends Wilson, or whomever else she's cajoled to her side, to accomplish this. If none of this is possible, she at least wants one inoculation syringe full of the 26 Draconis Strain and an urn or vial from the Medlab or Science Labs so as to have something to return with. If things go bad, Clayton tries to kidnap Dr. Flynn and escape with as much as possible on the EEV.

THE INFECTION SPREADS: While the PCs struggle with how to react to Clayton, more PCs are affected by the 26 Draconis Strain inoculation, turning more and more players into antagonists possibly until only a single unturned PC remains.

PREPARE TO BE BOARDED: A heavy clang against the hull tells the PCs that another ship has made contact and docked with the *Cronus*. A system check confirms this. This is in fact the corporate-sponsored marauder ship *Sotillo*, whose signature might have been picked up earlier by the *Montero* or the *Cronus*.

The *Sotillo*'s crew hung back for most of the scenario to see what's going on; now they have chosen to board the *Cronus* and take her cargo, blasting their way through the airlock. They don't wear compression suits, and they soon find out they got themselves into more than they bargained for. If PCs have been killed or turned into Abominations, players can take over marauder characters to stay in the game. The crew of the *Sotillo* are described on page 11 and onward.

NOTE: Only add the *Sotillo* to the mix if you feel the need for another twist in the story, want to make the scenario longer, or really need replacement PCs. If the game is already moving toward a satisfactory climactic finale, feel free to skip the *Sotillo* altogether.

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USCSS SOTILLO

HAWKER SYSTEMS V-10C
MANTIS-CLASS RESUPPLY SHIP

A retired military hauler. The *Sotillo*'s independently-articulated fission engine pods are located on large maneuvering arms. The *Sotillo*'s engines are overpowered, and she is fitted with a tractor umbilical lock in order to tow smaller industrial cargo modules. She is equipped with magnetic docking clamps and a two-story cargo bay with a rear loading ramp. She has cryosleep chambers for six.



WHO'S ON WHOSE SIDE NOW? While Clayton tries to bribe the marauders into helping them, they aren't too excited about the idea of these creatures getting loose on the Frontier. Captain Bolaji weighs risk vs. a hefty paycheck before deciding whether to take Clayton, Wilson, and any xenomorphic materials aboard the *Sotillo* or simply cut and run.

It's unlikely the other PCs can convince the captain to rescue them, as they have no bargaining chip, but it might be possible for them to board the *Sotillo* and take it for themselves. Inadvertently, the marauders' presence gives the PCs a fighting chance to survive, and their ship is the way out of this.

The *Sotillo* crew can of course be infected by Neomorphic Motes on the *Cronus*, and/or turn into Abominations if they take the inoculation.

CONTAMINATION PROTOCOL: In Act III, Lucas's Personal Agenda is to use any means to stop Weyland-Yutani from getting their hands on the 26 Draconis Strain—meaning a direct confrontation between Lucas and Clayton is very likely. Lucas might even try to sabotage or destroy the *Cronus* (see page 25 for information on how that can be done). If the other PCs destroy Lucas's physical body, he ceases to be a PC and turns into an NPC. He uploads himself to the mainframe of the *Cronus* and triggers a reactor overload. He freezes the locks on Clayton's EEV. If the *Sotillo* has been introduced, the PCs' best choice may be to take the ship. It takes some work to release the locks on the EEV (a Turn of work and a **HEAVY MACHINERY** roll).

RUN AS FAST AS YOU CAN: One way or another, there is a high probability that the *Cronus* is destroyed—by Lucas or by other PCs seeking to destroy the Abominations and the xenomorphic material. To escape the destruction of the *Cronus*, the PCs must be far enough away from the explosion so as to not be caught up in it. If they leave on the EEV pod, they survive automatically. If they leave on the *Sotillo*, have the pilot make a **PILOTING** roll at –2. Failure means that the ship's FTL drive is destroyed, leaving the *Sotillo* drifting in space. If you like, read the boxed text "Surviving the Blast" (below) to the players. Have them think they have survived—but it might not be over yet.

SURVIVING THE BLAST

As you accelerate, g-forces slam you hard into your padded seat. The Cronus grows smaller and smaller in the distance. The safety harnesses cut into your waist and shoulders, and you can't even catch your breath. Just before you black out, there is a flash of light where the Cronus used to be, followed by a tornado in space. Your eyes are seared shut by a shockwave of white and you are rocked violently as gamma rays assault you. You try to open your eyes, but all you can see is blues, purples, and oranges blasting through space. After a minute, you realize you are alive. You remember to breathe. It's going to be okay.

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IT ISN'T OVER UNTIL IT'S OVER

If the PCs escaped on the *Sotillo*, it's possible that one or more Stage III or Stage IV Abominations have climbed aboard her hull before the PCs took off. If so, it isn't over yet. Have the surviving player(s) sigh in relief, and rest long enough to relieve their **STRESS LEVEL**. As their adrenaline rush subsides, they begin prepping the displacement drive for FTL speeds. They gaze out at the stars, and two fists slam hard against the viewport. Instead of the cosmos, they stare into the eyes of a monster.

One of the Abominations is trying to smash through the cockpit viewport. While it isn't strong enough to, the PCs don't know that—and the beast can damage it. Again and again the rage-filled monstrosity crashes its bulbous fists into the reverberating viewport. With the fourth blow, the window catches the glint of a faraway star as a hairline crack begins to splinter across its surface. **STRESS LEVEL** +1 for all PCs inside.

If the PCs activate the viewport shields, there is a good chance they maim or kill one of the Abominations in the process (it gets its head or limb stuck between the closing metal sheets). If the PCs don't get all the remaining Abominations off the hull, the creatures damage the *Sotillo* and she ends up adrift as well. ■

EPILOGUE

AGENDAS & STORY POINTS

After it's all over, evaluate how well the players followed their PC's Personal Agendas for Act III, and hand out a Story Point to each player who did. Then have the players reveal all their Personal Agendas for the scenario if they so wish, and have a debriefing discussion. These can be a lot of fun!

Story Points belong to players, not PCs, and players can keep their Story Points to use in the next Cinematic Scenario if they wish. No player can ever have more than three Story Points, however. ■

SIGNING OFF

Here is a suggested sign-off message by one of the PCs, assuming anyone is still alive. The player of this PC can read the following message aloud, or adapt it according to what happened in the scenario.

Final report of the commercial starship Montero. [PC NAME] reporting. Only [NUMBER] of us have survived. The rest of the crew are dead, as are the crew of the Science Exploration Vehicle Cronus. Both ships and their cargoes destroyed. It's up to the Colonial Marshals to take it from here and clean up this mess. This is [PC NAME], signing off.

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APPENDIX I:

THE XENOMORPHS

A range of different Xenomorphs are described in the full ALIEN roleplaying game. Here, you'll get a sample of two varieties. In combat, Xenomorphs follow special rules—primarily, they have a Speed rating and they have signature attacks.

SKILLS: Xenomorphs don't have attributes like humans. They can use specific skills, and then roll a number of Base Dice equal to their skill level only. Xenomorphs can have skill levels much higher than humans.

ARMOR RATING: Most Xenomorphs also have a thick hide, resistant to attacks, giving them a natural Armor Rating (see page 64 in the rulebook).

HEALTH: When a Xenomorph is reduced to zero Health, it isn't Broken in the way a human is. Instead, roll a D6 on the critical injury table to the right. If a Xenomorph with zero Health is injured again, roll again on the critical injury table.

SPECIAL ABILITIES: Some Xenomorphs have special actions beyond the signature attacks. This is specified under each Xenomorph's description.

SPEED

Xenomorphs are often much faster than human beings. This is represented by their Speed rating. Speed has two uses:

- **IN STEALTH MODE** (see page 51 in the rulebook), the Xenomorph can move two zones per point of Speed each Turn. Humans can only move two zones, i.e. they have a Speed of 1.
- **IN COMBAT**, a Xenomorph gets to act one time for each point of Speed in each Round. Draw one initiative card for each point of Speed. At each point of action, the xenomorph gets to perform one fast and one slow action.

SIGNATURE ATTACKS

Most Xenomorphs attack only in close combat, at **ENGAGED** range. However, they don't make ordinary close combat attacks. Instead, each time a Xenomorph attacks, roll a D6 or choose an attack on the table for the creature's signature attacks, and resolve the effects. Some signature attacks are extremely deadly. ■

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CRITICAL INJURIES ON XENOMORPHS

D6	CRIT	EFFECT
1	Rise Again	The Xenomorph falls to the ground, seemingly dead, but it's a ruse. If it's attacked again, or on its next initiative, it regains one point of Health and rises—fueled by instinctive hatred.
2	Wounded	The Xenomorph staggers, bleeding severely. It gets Speed –1 (down to a minimum of 1, losing the lowest initiative), but regains one point of Health. Roll a D6 at the start of each Round. On 1–3, it tries to escape.
3	Desperate Action	The Xenomorph is severely wounded and cries out in alien fury. It immediately gets to perform a fast and a slow action, outside of the normal turn order. Roll a D6: On 1–3, it tries to escape (if it succeeds it regains half its Health). On 4–6, it instantly attacks the closest opponent. If it fails to inflict any damage, the creature dies. If it succeeds, it regains one point of Health.
4	Last Breath	The Xenomorph is mortally wounded and contorts wildly. On its next initiative, it will try to kill the nearest victim, then the beast dies. If it's wounded again before then, it dies instantly.
5–6	Torn Apart	Instant death. The Xenomorph is torn apart or crushed amidst shrieks of rage. Severely mutilated, it can only be Analyzed with OBSERVATION –2.

NEOMORPH

The term Neomorph is the common name for the endoparasitic extraterrestrial organism (EEO) that was originally encountered by humans on Planet 4 of an uncharted system in Sector 87. It is believed that an ecological disaster there brought on by the release of Agent A0-3959X.91-15 in the atmosphere led to the accelerant settling on and mutating native fungal and insect life to produce a living nightmare. Similar to a Xenomorph XX121, the Neomorph parasite (*P. celerius*) is delivered to a host via a carrier organism (*Tachinidae tabellarium*). Once implanted, the parasite gestates within a living host who is killed by the creature's violent birth. There are a number of differences, however, causing the creature to be classified separately.

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Stage IV: Juvenile Neomorph

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PHYSICAL ATTRIBUTES: Appearance-wise, Neomorphs are eyeless and have gray-white translucent skin, a fleshy spiked tail, an elongated bulbous head, and a sphincter-like facial orifice that distends to reveal a mouth full of cruel teeth. While their blood is translucent yellow like that of a Xenomorph, it is not acidic. They make subtle clicking sounds and exhibit animal snarls and screeches, as well as making a distinct hooting sound as adults. Neomorphs are more animalistic than their Xenomorph brethren and are clearly not as intelligent.

STAGES: A Neomorph's life cycle is broken down into five known stages that are covered below, as well as various termination protocols associated with each stage.

STERILIZATION: Neomorphs are genetically programmed to kill all life. Believed by some to be a derivative of the black liquid, *P. celerius* was likely designed by the Engineers to clear a planet of any indigenous species still living after Agent A0-3959X.91-15 had wiped out the majority of a planet's population.

STAGE I: NEOMORPHIC EGG SACS

Small, bulbous pods that grow like fungus, the egg sacs are the result of the mutagenic Agent A0-3959X.91-15 interacting with pollen and microbial elements on a planet or in a spacecraft. Once formed, these bird's egg-sized pods tend to grow in clutches of 2D6—and there are often several clutches in any infected area. The egg sacs are the delivery system for the Neomorphic Motes (see Stage II).

CONTAINMENT AND TERMINATION PROTOCOL: The best way to be rid of the Egg Sacs is to expose them to severe temperature changes—they can be destroyed with fire or made inert with liquid nitrogen (at least until they thaw).

STAGE II: NEOMORPHIC MOTES

When the egg sacs are disturbed, they release what appears to be a puff of pollen. In reality, it is a synchronized swarm of highly infectious *Tachinidae tabellarium* motes, smaller than grains of sand. Possessing a primal hive intelligence, the motes target the nearest potential host and zero-in on an unprotected orifice such as the eyes, ears, nose, throat, or an open wound. From there they enter the bloodstream and inject microscopic amounts of Agent A0-3959X.91-15 into the victim's white blood cells.

INFECTION: Exposure to Neomorphic Motes is normally handled as a disease with Virulence 9. If the Sickness Roll fails, the patient enters Stage III within one Shift. No more Sickness Rolls are made.

For the purposes of this Cinematic scenario, you are well within your rights to skip the roll and simply decide which PC or NPC is infected and enters Stage III and when, for maximum dramatic effect.

CONTAINMENT AND TERMINATION PROTOCOL: Neomorphic Mote tend to avoid smoke and are killed by fire.

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STAGE III: NEOMORPHIC BLOODBURSTER

Once the Motes enter a host's bloodstream, they deliver their microscopic payload and die. The injected Agent A0-3959X.91-15 begins to mutate white blood cells as they circulate throughout the body until they form a cancerous growth that becomes lodged in a vein or arterial wall. This tumor can take root in any bodily area of sufficient mass—such as the lungs, the digestive tract, the esophagus, or even the brain. Forming an amniotic sack, the tumor begins rapidly converting the host's own mutated cells into a larval Bloodburster.

If lodged in a region of the body with dense muscle or bone and no easy egress, the gestating creature develops dorsal spines to aid in its escape. When the newly formed Bloodburster is ready to be born, it violently removes itself from the host—using its inordinate strength, spines, teeth, and claws to cut and tear through flesh, bone, and sinew. The process causes severe hemorrhaging and massive tissue damage in the host, is always fatal, and results in the birth of a Bloodburster.

Bloodbursters have a bulbous head with sharp canines, and run about on all fours. These rabid quadrupedal creatures rely on their speed and agility to avoid damage. Emerging about 0.3 meters in length, Bloodbursters continue to grow exponentially, visibly getting larger as they move about. Highly aggressive, they lash out at anything and everything around them. They use their claws, tail, and teeth to savagely maul their victims.

BIRTH: A patient entering Stage III is immediately killed outright by the birth of the Bloodburster. The newly born Bloodburster takes one Round to sluggishly free itself from its amniotic sack. As soon as it is free, it flies into a savage rage and attacks any living creature it encounters. See the table of signature attacks below. After just a few Turns, the Bloodburster enters Stage IV (juvenile Neomorph).

SPRINT: As a slow action, the Bloodburster can sprint as if having used two run actions, i.e. through two zones or from an adjacent zone directly into **ENGAGED** range from a target.

CONTAINMENT AND TERMINATION PROTOCOL: The best bet is to attack a Bloodburster right after birth—before it has sluggishly freed itself from its amniotic sack (above). Fire or any serious damage done to the creature at this time causes it to run off and hide while it rapidly grows to its juvenile form.

BLOODBURSTER ATTACKS

D6	ATTACK
1–3	**ESCAPE.** With a snarl, the Bloodburster flees, moving two zones away in a single action, into the nearest air duct if possible. As soon as the PCs lose line of sight, combat ends and stealth mode ensues. After D6 Turns, the Bloodburster grows into a Juvenile Neomorph and starts stalking the PCs.
4	**TERRIFYING HISS.** The Bloodburster jumps onto the victim, showing its razor-sharp teeth and hissing. The victim must make an immediate Panic Roll.
5	**LEG BITE.** With a snarl, the Bloodburster bites the victim's leg. Roll for the attack using six Base Dice, Damage 2. If the attack causes damage, it automatically inflicts critical injury #53 (even if the victim is not Broken), triggering an immediate Panic Roll.
6	**THROAT BITE.** The Bloodburster bites the victim's throat. Roll for the attack using eight Base Dice, Damage 1. If the attack causes damage, it automatically inflicts critical injury #61 (even if the victim is not Broken), triggering an immediate Panic Roll.

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TYPICAL STATS

NEOMORPHIC BLOODBURSTER

SPEED: 3

HEALTH: 2

SKILLS: Mobility 9, Observation 6

ARMOR RATING: 3 (zero against fire damage)

TYPICAL STATS

NEOPHYTE (JUVENILE NEOMORPH)

SPEED: 3

HEALTH: 4

SKILLS: Mobility 10, Observation 6

ARMOR RATING: 4 (2 against fire damage)

STAGE IV: NEOPHYTE (JUVENILE NEOMORPH)

Growing from 1.2 to 1.8 meters in length, a juvenile Neomorph continues to maneuver on all fours. While their heads are still bulbous, they have begun to elongate and taper to a point. They are aggressive hunters who are hard to frighten away. Juveniles target one prey animal in a pack and devote all resources to taking that prey down, even going so far as to track it if it escapes. Feral and ferocious, a juvenile Neomorph uses its sharp-tipped tail and teeth to attack.

EVOLVING: After one Shift, the juvenile Neomorph enters Stage V and becomes an adult Neomorph.

SPRINT: As a slow action, the Neomorph can sprint as if having used two run actions, i.e. through two zones or from an adjacent zone directly into **ENGAGED** range from a target.

CONTAINMENT AND TERMINATION PROTOCOL: Even when taking weapons fire, a juvenile Neomorph is so focused on the attack that it ignores damage to itself until it becomes critical. Overwhelming concentrated fire will eventually take the thing out, if it doesn't get you first.

STAGE V: ADULT NEOMORPH

As it reaches adulthood, the Neomorph's smooth, eyeless head becomes more elongated and pointed. Soon, it assumes a gaunt, bipedal stance, reaching a height of 2.1 meters or more. When the creature's mouth closes, its jawline is imperceptible, giving it an inquisitive, ethereal appearance. When provoked, the adult Neomorph's upper jaw protrudes in a manner similar to a goblin shark, allowing it to grasp prey and pull it in for the kill. As adults they utilize stealth tactics to hunt their prey, but they are still voracious carnivores.

SHORT LIFESPAN: The life cycle and metabolism of Neomorphs is so fast that they quickly burn themselves out. An adult Neomorph typically dies of natural causes within 24 hours (four Shifts). Fungus interacting with the decaying corpse will be transformed into new spore sacs, continuing the cycle.

CONTAINMENT AND TERMINATION PROTOCOL: Adult Neomorphs go down quick with a full burst from a pulse rifle, but any automatic weapon does the job eventually. A finishing shot to the head is a good idea, as these creatures have been known to get up and attack even when they seem to be dead.

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NEOMORPH ATTACKS

D6	ATTACK
1	**TERRIFYING HISS.** The Neomorph leans in close to the victim, showing its razor-sharp teeth and hissing. The victim must make an immediate Panic Roll.
2	**TAIL SLASH.** The Neomorph pivots, slashing its victim with its sharp tail. The victim is attacked using ten Base Dice, Damage 2. The attack is armor piercing, halving any Armor Rating.
3	**DEADLY GRAB.** The Neomorph jumps at its victim, grabbing it and dragging it away. Roll for the attack using eight Base Dice, Damage 1. If it hits, the Neomorph immediately drags the victim into the next zone (MEDIUM range) before releasing it. The victim falls prone, drops any hand-held items, and must make an immediate Panic Roll.
4	**LEAPING ATTACK.** The Neomorph jumps at the victim. Roll for the attack using eight Base Dice, Damage 1. If the attack is successful, the victim is thrown to the ground and must make an immediate Panic Roll, and the Neomorph immediately performs an extra attack with ten Base Dice, Damage 2 (does not count as an action). The extra attack cannot be blocked.
5	**THROAT BITE.** The Neomorph bites the victim's throat. Roll for the attack using eight Base Dice, Damage 1. If the attack causes damage, it automatically inflicts critical injury #61 (even if the victim is not Broken), triggering an immediate Panic Roll.
6	**TAIL SPIKE.** The Neomorph impales the victim with its razor-sharp tail. Roll for the attack using seven Base Dice, Damage 1. The attack is armor piercing, halving any Armor Rating. If the attack causes damage, it automatically triggers critical injury #66 (even if the victim is not Broken), killing the victim outright.

ADULT NEOMORPH

SPEED: 2

HEALTH: 6

SKILLS: Mobility 9, Observation 8

ARMOR RATING: 6 (3 against fire damage)

SPRINT: As a slow action, the Neomorph can sprint as if having used two run actions, i.e. through two zones or from an adjacent zone directly into ENGAGED range from a target.

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ABOMINATION

A monstrous mutation of the human form brought about by a genetic accelerant, an Abomination goes through several stages over a few Shifts of gestation. What follows are the symptoms and stages of infection via the 26 Draconis Strain of Agent A0-3959X.91-15. Other strains of the chemical may create variations of this mutation process.

STAGE I: INFECTED

TRAITS: Anger, Confusion, Acidosis

Changes begin with the onset of rapid skin mottling that starts in the subject's extremities and moves inward towards the core body. Eventually the subject's skull begins to soften and elongate as their brain grows and is rewired. By the end of this stage, the process becomes excruciating and the subject lashes out. As acidosis takes effect, the subject's pH levels shift significantly.

INFECTION: Exposure to the 26 Draconis Strain is normally handled as a disease with Virulence 6. If the Sickness Roll fails, the patient enters Stage I.

For the purposes of this Cinematic scenario, you as GM are allowed skip the roll and simply decide if a PC is infected, for maximum dramatic effect.

Within one Shift, the patient starts to exhibit the first symptoms, which causes their **STRESS LEVEL** to increase by one. Within another Shift, the patient typically advances to Stage II.

STAGE II: "MUTANT"

TRAITS: Aggressive Dementia, Cerebral Dysmorphia

Painful cellular mutations ravage the Abomination's body, causing them to take on an aggressive posture. The subject's limbs distend and become pliable, allowing them to contort into strange positions. The brain and skull continue to elongate and the subject takes on a feral appearance and attitude. Strength, speed, and agility are all heightened. Only a rudimentary knowledge of their former self remains, but they are still aware enough to use basic tools and weapons.

EFFECTS: The subject gets Speed 2, i.e. it gets to act twice per Round. **STRENGTH** increases by 3 (and Health along with it). **AGILITY** is increased by 1, while **EMPATHY** is reduced to 1. **EMPATHY**- based skills cannot be used. Firearms and other technological items cannot be used. The subject becomes immune to **MANIPULATION**.

At this point, the subject becomes aggressive and attacks other humans on sight. An infected PC can play out one such attack, then the subject turns into an NPC controlled by the GM. Within one Shift, the subject advances to Stage III.

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STAGE III: "REVENANT"

TRAITS: Instinctual Aggression, Advanced Dementia

The subject's body is in an advanced state of DNA recoding. A translucent, gelatinous cowl has grown over most of their head, revealing a sunken and hideous caricature of their former visage beneath. As the structure of the subject's original features dissolves into the acidic gelatin, their skull becomes more pronounced. Eventually, any semblance of human origin recedes and becomes barely visible within the cowl. The subject's feet each splay into three thick toes, their arms elongate like a primate's, and they sprint using their knuckles to propel themselves.

EFFECTS: **STRENGTH** increases by a further 2 (and Health along with it). **AGILITY** is increased by 1 more. **WITS** is reduced to 1. No skills based on **WITS** except **OBSERVATION** can be used. Immune to **MANIPULATION** and panic. Cowl gives a natural Armor Rating of 3. The subject is now handled as a full Xenomorph and gets its own table for signature attacks (see next page). Within four Shifts, the subject advances to Stage IV.

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TYPICAL STATS
"REVENANT"

SPEED: 2
HEALTH: 8
SKILLS: Mobility 5, Observation 3
ARMOR RATING: 3 (none against fire damage)

TYPICAL STATS
"BELUGA-HEAD"

SPEED: 2
HEALTH: 10
SKILLS: Mobility 5, Observation 3
ARMOR RATING: 6 (3 against fire damage)

STAGE IV: "BELUGA-HEAD"

TRAITS: Complete Cellular Metamorphosis

The subject's gelatinous cowl grows opaque and solidifies as their eyes grow dark and shift to the sides of their bulbous head. Their skin turns a translucent mottled gray and their features grow similar in appearance to a Xenomorph XX121, albeit with a much shorter head, more prominent eyes and elongated arms. The subject moves about on all fours like an ape and no longer retains any human characteristics. While not as powerful or intelligent as a Xenomorph XX121, the Beluga-Head is a force to be reckoned with.

EFFECTS: As Stage III, with **STRENGTH** increasing by yet another 2 (and Health along with it). Cowl now gives a natural Armor Rating of 6.

ABOMINATION ATTACKS (STAGE III AND IV)

D6	ATTACK
1	**HORRIBLE ROAR. The Abomination screams in fury. All humans in SHORT range must make an immediate panic roll.**
2	**FIST STRIKE. The Abomination strikes its victim with a powerful punch. Roll for the attack with ten Base Dice, Damage 1.**
3	**THROW. The Abomination grabs the victim and tries to slam it into the nearest hard surface. Roll for the attack using nine Base Dice, Damage 1. If the attack hits, the victim lands prone at SHORT range from the Abomination, drops any hand-held items, and must make an immediate Panic Roll.**
4	**POUNCE. The Abomination leaps onto its victim like a big monkey. Roll for the attack using eight Base Dice, Damage 1. If the attack hits, the victim is knocked to the ground, drops any hand-held items, and must make an immediate Panic Roll. The Abomination then starts pounding the victim with its powerful fists. This is resolved as an immediate bonus attack with twelve Base Dice, Damage 2.**
5	**ARM PULL. The Abomination grabs the victim's arm and tries to pull it clean off with its bare hands. Roll for the attack using six Base Dice, Damage 1. If the attack causes damage, it automatically triggers critical injury #54 (even if the victim is not Broken), triggering an immediate Panic Roll.**
6	**HEAD CRUSH. The Abomination grabs the victim's head and tries to crush it with its bare hands. Roll for the attack using seven Base Dice, Damage 1. If the attack causes damage, it automatically triggers critical injury #64 (even if the victim is not Broken), killing the victim outright.**

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APPENDIX II:
TALENTS

SCIENTIST TALENT:
ANALYSIS

You can roll for **OBSERVATION** to gain insight regarding strange and alien artifacts or creatures that you encounter and get a chance to study for at least one Turn. For every ✠ you roll, you get to ask the GM one of the questions below.

- Is it human or alien?
- Is it dead or alive?
- How old is it?
- What is its purpose?
- How does it work?
- What problems could it cause?

The GM must answer truthfully, but is allowed to give vague or incomplete answers in order to avoid spoiling the scenario.

A successful Analyze roll also reduces the **STRESS LEVEL** of all other PCs within **SHORT** range by one, while a failed roll increases other PCs' stress levels by one

KID TALENT:
BENEATH NOTICE

No matter what horrible situations you end up in, you always seem to make it out unscathed, probably because no one ever pays much attention to you. When you roll for a critical injury on yourself, you get to re-roll the dice and choose the result that you prefer.

MEDIC TALENT:
COMPASSION

This isn't just a job for you. You truly care about the people under your care. You can push any skill roll based on **EMPATHY** twice, not just once like other characters. Each push increases your **STRESS LEVEL** by one.

COLONIAL MARINE TALENT:
OVERKILL

You don't run and hide when the going gets tough. Instead of panicking in the face of mortal danger, you can turn your fear into aggression and use it as a weapon against your enemy. You can trigger the Overkill effect when you make a Panic Roll—see page 70 in the rulebook.

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COMPANY AGENT TALENT:

PERSONAL SAFETY

The interests of the company always come first, no matter what. And you represent the company. That means your own safety is paramount—other crew members are expendable. If you are attacked or otherwise end up in fatal danger, and if another PC or friendly NPC is within **SHORT** range (the same zone), you can make a **MANIPULATION** roll (straight roll, not opposed, and does not count as an action). If you succeed, you see the threat coming and find a clever way to make the other character suffer the attack or hazard instead of you. Using this talent increases your **STRESS LEVEL** by one.

PILOT TALENT:

RECKLESS

You live for the rush of adrenaline through your veins, pushing harder than others dare. You can push any skill roll based on **AGILITY** twice, not just once like other characters. Each push increases your **STRESS LEVEL** by one.

OFFICER TALENT:

PULL RANK

You can use your **COMMAND** skill to order other non-officer PCs and NPCs around, as long as they belong to the same organization as you. To force someone to follow your orders and perform a specific action, roll **COMMAND** against the target's **MANIPULATION**. If successful, the target must follow your order, even if it means harm or danger to themselves. Your **STRESS LEVEL** increases by one each time you do this. Note also that each roll only covers one specific action. You cannot stop actions triggered by Panic Rolls using this talent.

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